
LEAGUE OF LEGENDS
GAREN
FIRST SHIELD
ANTHONY REYNOLDS

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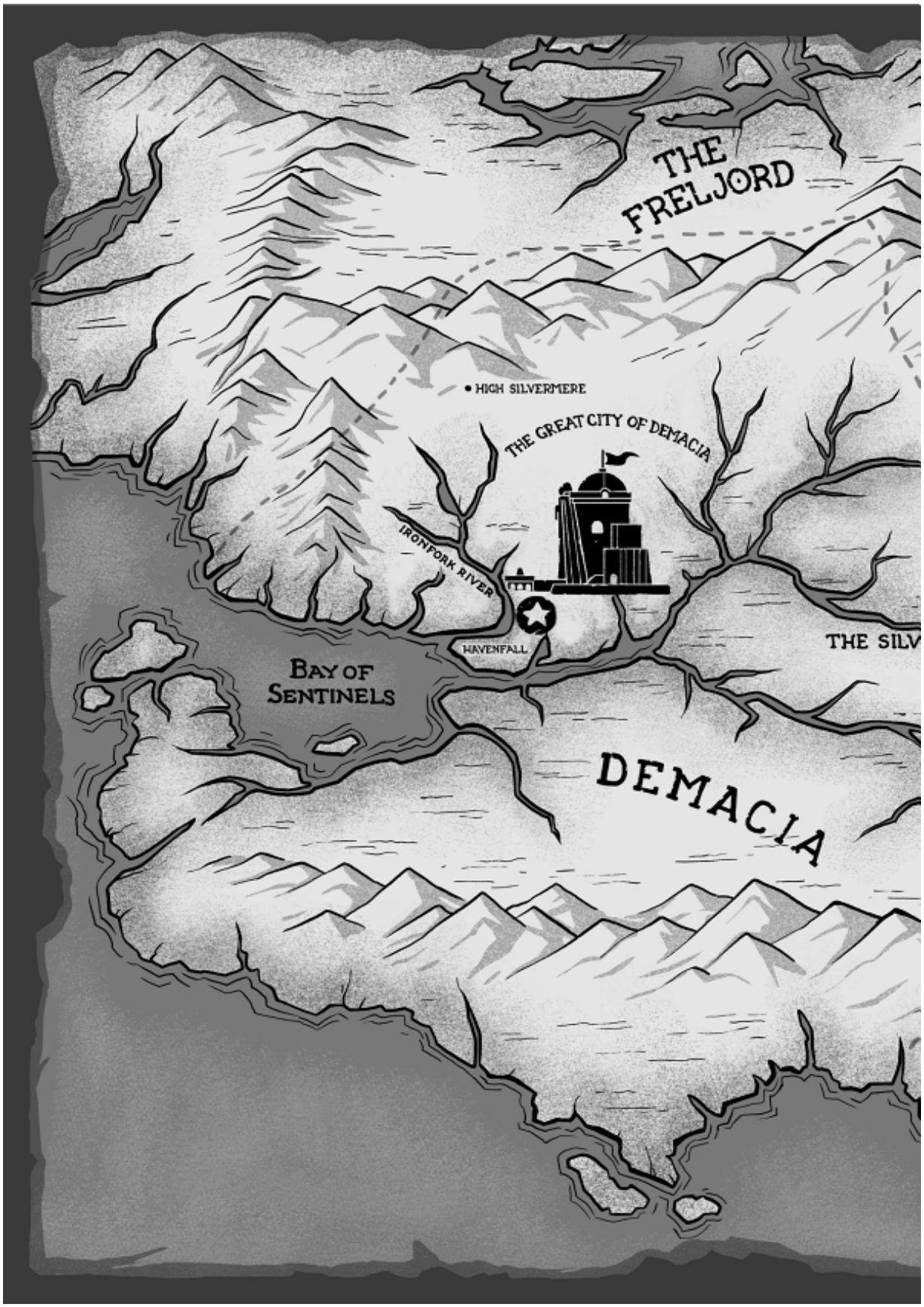
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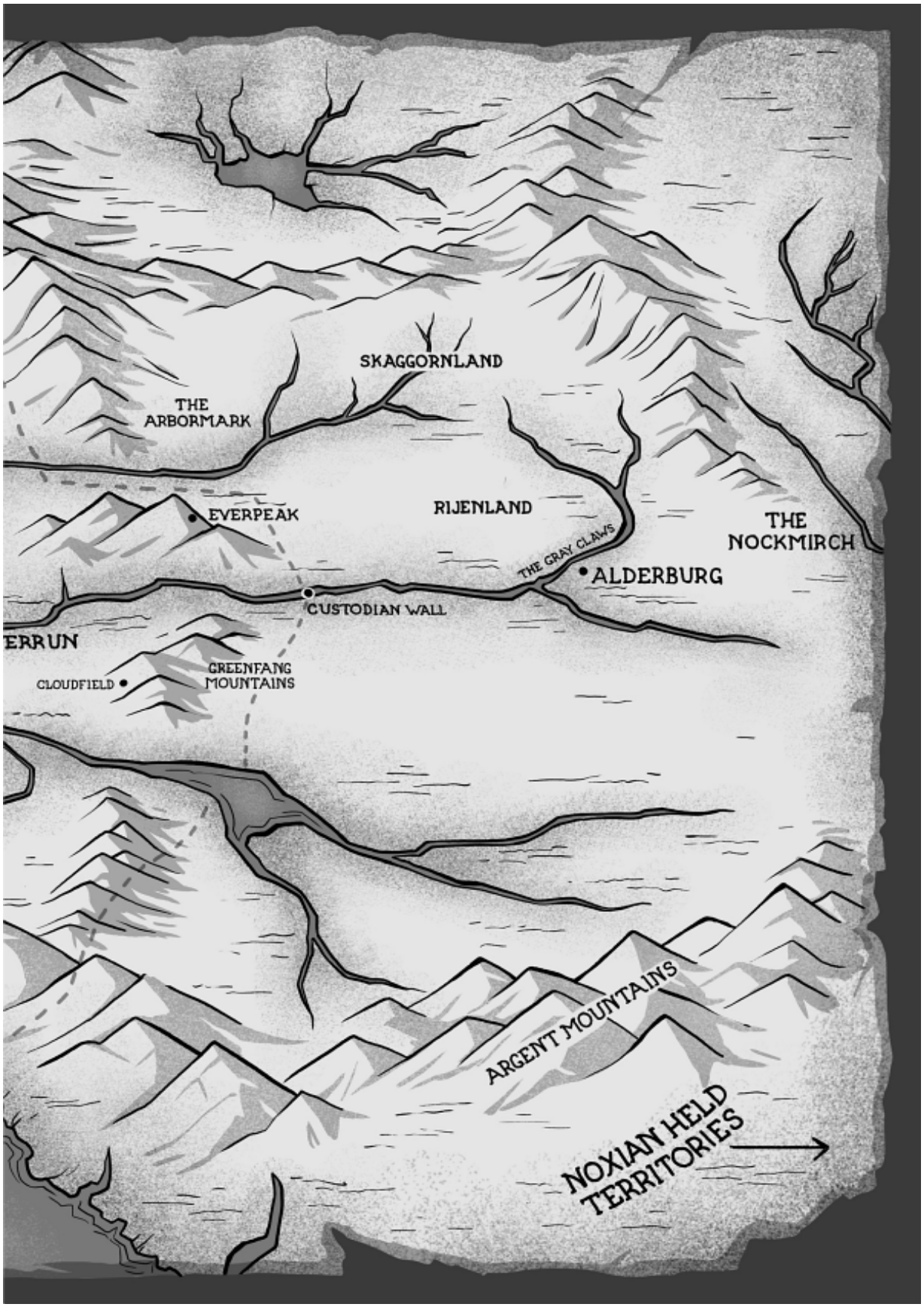
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“While the Dauntless Vanguard stands, Demacia will never fall.”

King Argostan of Demacia, Second Epoch


THE FRELJORD
HIGH SILVERMERE
THE GREAT CITY OF DEMACIA
IRONFORK RIVER
HAVENFALL
THE SILV
BAY OF SENTINELS
DEMACIA


SKAGGORNLAND
THE ARBORMARK
EVERPEAK
RIJENLAND
THE NOCKMIRCH
THE GRAY CLAWS
ALDERBURG
CUSTODIAN WALL
ERRUN
CLOUDFIELD
GREENFANG MOUNTAINS
ARGENT MOUNTAINS
NOXIAN HELD TERRITORIES

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Chapter One

It was two hours before dawn as Garen ran through the streets of the Great City. The chill of winter was already creeping down from the north, yet he was covered in a sheen of sweat.

He ran in full field plate, as he had each morning for weeks. That armor was well made—as all Demacian armor was—but it was simple, well worn, and unadorned. Taking it off outside of the barracks now felt like a luxury to him, one that he could not afford anymore.

On top of the weight of his armor, he carried a heavy sack filled with rocks, hefted onto one broad shoulder. Many would have struggled to even lift it, but Garen bore the burden stoically, running hard, and refusing to give in.

He had to be strong. He had to be ready. There must be no weakness within him.

The king is dead.

With every pounding step, he relived that awful day, searching for anything he could have done differently. Had he been stronger, more observant, more focused, perhaps he could have averted disaster.

Garen continued to run along Defender's Way, passing beneath the gaze of the titanic statues flanking that broad road, and circled the domed Hall of Valor, where the name of every fallen blue-cloak was recorded and honored. Too many new names. Too many of his own. He turned northward, crossing Triumph Bridge, then passed beneath the heavily fortified tower of Shield Arch. Cutting east, he climbed Victory Hill, flanked by civic buildings of pale stone, then turned through the carved gateway into the famed Garden

of Orlon.

For another hour he ran. He was breathing hard, and had to switch the heavy sack of rocks from one shoulder to the other frequently, but he refused to slow his pace. From childhood, he'd been taught that to succeed he had to be willing to work harder than anyone else, day in, day out, and not to give in when others might falter. Indeed, all he had achieved through his life had come through relentless effort, training, and discipline.

And yet, it had not been enough to save the king… *He* had not been enough.

He would become better, more disciplined. Hard and relentless, like Demacia's enemies.

Gritting his teeth, Garen pushed down the sudden rise of surging emotions and lengthened his stride, pounding through the North Ward. The towering gilt portals of the Argent Gate were still closed for the night, and its guards snapped off quick salutes as he approached. He nodded in return, then turned eastward, following the curve of the wall.

"That was Garen Crownguard," one of the soldiers remarked, behind him.

"Heard the captain's sister's still missing…" said another, and Garen's expression darkened.

He had found Lux fleeing the city, in the dark days after the king's assassination, leading a ragtag group of mages to safety… mages he'd sworn to apprehend.

He had let her go, even after seeing the truth of her nature with his own eyes. He had lied about it to Jarvan, his oldest friend and sworn lord.

The shame of that lie had almost broken him. It might yet.

Garen kept running, but no amount of physical exertion seemed able to quell his roiling emotions.

Daybreak was *just* creeping over the horizon as he returned to the barracks. Soldiers were training here, some practicing with sword and shield, others lifting heavy iron bars and dragging heavy chains affixed to great blocks of masonry across the gravel.

Garen came to a halt and heaved the sack to the ground, sucking in great lungfuls of air.

“Just one load of rocks today, sword-captain?” remarked Merrek, First Shield’s grizzled sergeant, taking a break from sparring.

“Just the one, shield-sergeant,” Garen said, accepting a wooden cup of water offered to him by a young, wide-eyed attendant. “Thank you, Dom,” he said. Garen made a point to know not just the names of every soldier in the Dauntless Vanguard, but also those who served them. The youngster reddened and gave him a clipped salute before taking his leave, almost falling over himself in his haste.

“The great Garen Crownguard, sword-captain of the Vanguard, knowing his name?” said Merrek. “That boy will be dining on that story for weeks.”

Merrek grinned at Garen’s discomfort—he knew how Garen hated such talk—and rested his weighted training blade on his shoulder. His smile faded, however, as he took in Garen’s appearance, noting the dark shadows under his eyes and unshaven cheeks.

“Still not sleeping, captain?” he said, lowering his voice.

Garen didn’t answer, and Merrek knew well enough not to push the issue. Instead, Merrek turned his attention to the soldier he had been sparring before Garen’s arrival.

“New member of First Shield,” he announced, nodding toward her. “Cithria of Cloudfield.”

The soldier saluted sharply, standing tall.

Garen could feel sweat trickling down his back, cold inside his armor. Steam was rising from him in the chill of morning. He returned the salute, and locked eyes with his new charge.

Her dark hair was pulled back in a ponytail, and her cheeks flushed from exertion. She wore armor of gleaming silver, and a blue cloak hung from her shoulders, matching the rest of the Dauntless Vanguard.

Garen had penned the letter inviting her to undertake the Testing, and kept an eye on her progress. As it turned out, she passed the grueling, month-long evaluation with scores not seen since… well, since Garen had himself taken it.

“I read the reports of your action at Meltridge. I was impressed,” said Garen. “I have no doubt you will serve the Dauntless Vanguard with courage.”

“Thank you, sword-captain,” said Cithria. She was young, and more than a little overawed, but there was steel in her. “I will do my best.”

“Nothing less will do in times like these, soldier,” said Garen. He saluted her, and Merrek indicated for her to join the others of First Shield.

As she jogged off, Merrek rubbed his shoulder, grimacing. “Damn quick with a blade, she is, too,” he said.

“Getting slow, old man?” said Garen.

In his mid-forties, with more than a hint of gray in his hair, Merrek was the oldest soldier of First Shield—barring Kriel, of course, but then Kriel was Stonehorn. Still, Merrek was as tough as they came, as strong as a draft horse, and his endurance put soldiers half his age to shame. He’d also been talking of retiring since he’d trained Garen in the Fourteenth Battalion. Probably since the day he joined the ranks.

“It’s true,” said Merrek, nodding solemnly. “Might be time I buy that old

fishing boat and find the love of a good woman. Ideally one who'll laugh at my jokes and never scold me for repeating my old stories."

"Perhaps one hard of hearing, then," said a voice from nearby. "Or better yet, completely stone deaf."

Garen and Merrek both glanced over at a soldier standing nearby, leaning against the barracks. Tall and wolf-lean, she had short-cropped dark hair and a small winged sword tattooed under her left eye. Her expression was deadpan.

Alys Morn.

"Haven't you got something better to be doing than making sport of your old sergeant, Morn?" said Merrek.

"Well I *was* enjoying watching the new recruit embarrass you with the sword," she replied, "but now that's over, this is the next best thing." She turned her unblinking gaze toward Garen, and gave him a nod. "Captain."

"Morn," said Garen, nodding back.

He was cast suddenly in shadow, as a giant presence behind him blotted out the low morning sun, and Garen turned to see Kriel looking down at him.

Garen was not a short man, not by any stretch. He was larger than most, even among the Vanguard, but the enormous figure of Kriel towered over him.

The minotaur was armored as the other members of First Shield, and his short, curving horns were steel tipped.

"Do you wish to train, sword-captain?" said Kriel, his voice a calm, resounding rumble, sounding something like a distant avalanche.

"It would be an honor, as always, Kriel," said Garen.

He moved to a nearby weapon rack, and selected a massive, two-handed

training sword.

He rolled his shoulders as he and the minotaur moved to a clear space on the training yard. Kriel wielded a sword as large as Garen's, though he held it easily in one hand. A huge slab-shield was strapped to his other arm.

Garen and Kriel saluted, and began to circle each other.

Grunting with effort, Garen swung his heavy broadsword toward his opponent. Kriel saw the blow coming, and met it with one of his own, the power in his strike reverberating through both swords.

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An hour later, with cold morning sunlight bathing the training yard, Garen was breathing hard and facing a different opponent—Aiguo, another veteran. This was the fifth of the eight members of First Shield he'd faced in succession, and his arms were leaden. Merrek had tried to end the session twice, but Garen kept pushing himself and his squad. The enemy would not give them time to catch their breath on the field of battle, so Garen had no intention of allowing that in the Vanguard's training.

Aiguo came at him, sword flashing. The soldier feinted high, then shifted his attack mid-strike to come at his captain's midsection. Garen read the move and neatly sidestepped, bringing his double-handed blade around in a scything arc. Aiguo took the blow on his shield, but it knocked him off balance, forcing him back a step. Garen made to follow it up and end the duel, but he spied the arrival of a messenger out of the corner of his eye. Raising a hand, he pulled himself short and stepped back from the fight.

One of the other watching members of First Shield, Eben Hess, scowled darkly and turned away.

"Lucky break, sword-captain," Aiguo said, flashing one of his customary

smiles. “I was just about to launch a series of strikes that would have humbled you in front of all of First Shield. Sorry, Hess, I guess you bet on the wrong blademaster.”

“You signaled that feint too early,” said Garen, waving the messenger forward. “You need to make me believe it.”

“The High Marshal requests your presence at a meeting of the Silver Council,” the messenger said.

“When?”

“Tenth bell, sir.”

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Chapter Two

Garen stood statue-still in the antechamber outside the council room doors, waiting to be admitted.

He'd bathed—though his cheeks remained unshaven—and his long blue cloak hung over his left shoulder, the color brilliant and rich against the silver of his armor. He hoped he didn't look as tired and weary as he felt.

His broadsword, *Judgment*, was scabbarded across his back.

At last, one of the council room doors swung soundlessly open, and the two guards posted to either side slammed the butts of their halberds onto the floor as an attendant ushered Garen inside.

Eight high-ranking individuals sat around the octagonal table at the heart of the council room. Each represented a vital facet of Demacia, including the military, the noble families, the treasury, and the mageseekers. Twice their number—a mix of attendants, advisors, seconds, and representatives of minor houses—stood behind them.

It was notable that the royal family's seat remained empty. The recommendations of this council typically required the approval of the monarch to be enacted, but times were anything but typical.

The late king's successor—Garen's closest friend, Jarvan—was not yet sworn into office.

And while Garen knew Jarvan to be a kind man, wise beyond his years, the heir to the throne was not himself. He had become obsessed with rooting out his father's assassin—the cursed mage Sylas—and wished to have nothing to do with matters of state focused on anything other than finding him. Everything else, he left to the council.

The eight council members were deep in discussion, and paid Garen no mind. High Marshal Tianna Crownguard, sitting at the council table in representation of the military, met his gaze and held up her hand, indicating for him to wait. He saluted crisply, and stood to attention to the side of the room.

Tianna was his father's sister, and while the two resembled each other in feature, they were as night and day in temperament and demeanor. Where his father, Pieter, was kind and forgiving, Tianna was severe and uncompromising. She expected much of those around her, but Garen knew she was every bit as strict with herself. It was one of the many reasons he looked up to her.

A career soldier with an impeccable military record, Tianna had served as sword-captain of the Dauntless Vanguard, leading the regiment before Garen's direct predecessor. She had only vacated the position after promotion to the rank of marshal, twelve years earlier, and the successes of the Vanguard under her leadership were legendary.

As a child, Garen had been terrified of her. Fear had slowly given way to awe, but a little of it remained, even now.

Seated directly opposite Tianna was her husband, Lord Eldred. Half of his regal face was obscured by a golden mask, and he wore a petricite disk inscribed with geometric symbols over his heart. Both were symbols of the Order of Mageseekers, of which he was the leader.

The mageseekers were an ancient order that traced its history back to the Founding, and in light of recent events, they'd been granted considerably more power. Garen found his thoughts drifting back to Lux, and his stomach churned.

As if sensing his unease, Lord Eldred turned his inscrutable gaze in his

direction. Garen remained still, not meeting the lord's eye, and after a moment, Eldred looked away.

Garen tried not to listen to the discussion of the council. He had little patience for their politicking at the best of times, but particularly right now, with unrest gripping Demacia, was not the time for debates and disagreements. Now was the time for action.

Jarvan may be rash in his fervor, but at least he was *doing* something.

Garen straightened as chairs were pushed back from the table, and the council members rose.

"We are in agreement, then," said Tianna. Her words were met with nods and muttered affirmations, though it looked to Garen like some were happier to say so than others. Slowly, the gaggle of politicians, heads of family and bureaucrats shuffled out of the room.

Garen noticed that Lord Eldred did not so much as exchange a glance with his wife as he left the room. He was not one for gossip, but it was understood within the family that there was little warmth between the two of them, and that the events of recent months had deepened that divide.

Finally, only Garen and Tianna remained, and the door clicked shut behind the last of her servants to leave. Garen continued standing to attention as Tianna neatened up the various papers and letters spread across the table before her. Once everything was arranged in ordered piles, she ushered Garen forward.

He saluted in formal Demacian fashion, crossing his arms over his chest, hands clenched into fists, and moved to stand across the table opposite Tianna.

She stared at him, appraising him coldly. He resisted the urge to look down at his feet.

“Strength through discipline,” Tianna said, by way of greeting.

“Honor through diligence,” answered Garen, without hesitation.

It was the Crownguard family motto, and the phrase had formed a cornerstone in Garen’s life, providing him stability and focus.

“The Vanguard are Demacia’s finest,” Tianna said. “They are our most important bulwark against the barbarians beyond our walls… and threats from within. I am disappointed that so many have been lost under your command in recent months. How many is it now? Forty soldiers?”

“Thirty-seven,” said Garen.

“Thirty-seven,” repeated Tianna. “I would not have thought the rabble following the Dregbourne traitor, *Sylas*,” she said, spitting the name out like poison, “would have proven so difficult for the Vanguard to tackle.”

Garen stared resolutely forward, his expression stoic.

It had been a trying few months. The enemy had proven elusive and tactically more astute than he had given them credit for, striking against isolated patrols and watch towers outside Demacia’s towns, but always slipping back into the forests and marshes as soon as a force gathered to face them.

“I underestimated them, and accept full responsibility,” admitted Garen. “I have been visiting the families of all the fallen to pay my respects and return their shields home.”

“Good,” said Tianna. “Hearing the wail of a grieving parent teaches humility. Perhaps it will also teach you to keep your soldiers *alive* in future.”

“I will do all in my power to make that so, High Marshal,” said Garen. “We have started coordinating our efforts with the ranger-knights, and I expect better results to follow.”

Tianna gave a noncommittal grunt, full of judgment. It had always been this way. Even now, a veteran who had led the Dauntless Vanguard for almost four years, Garen felt like a raw recruit before her.

“But this was not the reason I summoned you,” said Tianna. She picked up a piece of parchment covered in handwriting, looking at it coldly. “We received this dispatch yesterday. It comes from our ambassador to the Nockmirch.”

An independent nation to the east of Demacia, the Nockmirch had ever been staunch allies. Garen had passed through their lands twice before, and had formed an impression of them as tough, hardy folk. They had to be, living out there.

“You may be too young to remember Hargold. He is your great-uncle. My mother’s younger brother.”

“I remember him,” said Garen. “He visited High Silvermere when I was a boy.”

“Uncle Hargold has been our ambassador within the Nockmirch for nigh on a decade now. A deeply methodical and pragmatic man. Since he took up his post, his dispatches have reached us with precise regularity, arriving with every new moon.”

“Until now,” said Garen. The new moon was almost a week past.

“Until now,” agreed Tianna, “and something about this most recent dispatch feels… off. Here, this is his latest letter,” she said, passing it across the table to him. She then pushed across a second dispatch. “Compare it to this older one.”

Garen skimmed the two letters, looking for whatever it was Tianna saw. Both were written with precise handwriting, their language clipped and to the point. This was the writing of a soldier, or at least someone who had

once served in the ranks.

“I… am not sure what I’m missing?” said Garen, finally. He saw no real difference between the two.

“The phraseology is close, but there are some terms in the latest dispatch that do not sound like Uncle Hargold. And the handwriting is not quite the same. Look at the upcurl in the latest one. It is similar, but much more deliberate—like he took twice as long to write it.”

Garen looked again at the letters. He could *maybe* see what Tianna was referring to. Perhaps his great-uncle had rushed with the first letter?

“I don’t believe this latest dispatch was written by Hargold at all,” said Tianna.

“Oh?” said Garen, frowning. “Who do you believe did?”

Tianna shrugged. “I don’t know. Nor do I know why the Nockmirch would create this forgery. I want to know what they are hiding. I want to know what has happened to the ambassador, and what it means for Demacia.”

Garen’s hands clenched. He didn’t like the way this was heading.

“What are your orders?” he said.

“You are to journey to the Nockmirch and assess the situation. Check on Uncle Hargold. Ensure all is well.”

Garen stared straight ahead, not responding.

“You think this mission beneath you?”

“The king’s murderer is still out there,” said Garen. “My place is here, in Demacia.”

Tianna stared at him, eyes hard.

“Are you refusing a direct order, sword-captain?”

Garen blinked, and felt heat rise in his cheeks.

“Of course not, High Marshal,” he said, finally. “If this is your order, it will be done. But I do not agree with it.”

Tianna sighed, and rubbed her eyes. When she spoke again, she sounded tired.

“This has been a trying time,” she said. “And that’s why I cannot have you distracted, not now.”

“I’m fine, Aunt Tianna,” said Garen.

Tianna looked at him sharply.

“You look as though you bear the weight of the nation on your shoulders, *captain*,” she snapped. “But that burden is not yours to bear alone. It will crush you, and that will help no one—not yourself, not your soldiers, and certainly not Demacia.”

“If I had just—”

“Stop,” interrupted Tianna, raising her hand. “This mission is important, but it will also give you time away, to regain perspective. Demacia is more than any single individual—even its king.”

Garen’s jaw clenched.

“You will take three Shields, and travel east to the Nockmirch,” said Tianna. “The council felt it inappropriate to march to the Nockmirch unannounced with a larger force. It could be seen as threatening, apparently, though why an ally would see it as such is beyond me.”

Tianna turned and looked out the window.

“Storm clouds gather on the horizon, mark my words,” she said. “Go to the Nockmirch. Clear your head, and come back refreshed. I need you at your best. *Demacia* needs you at your best.”

Garen hoped none of his surging feelings were reflected on his face.

“I will leave before nightfall,” he said.

“Good,” said Tianna, turning her attention back to her papers. “You are dismissed, sword-captain. Duty calls.”

Garen saluted once more, though Tianna did not look up. Without further delay, he turned on his heel and marched from the room.

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Cithria walked onto the docks jutting into the wide, slow-moving Ironfork River, heading for their waiting ship. Ahead of her, the other members of First Shield made for a formidable sight.

She stayed close, desperately trying to look like she belonged among them. She’d idolized the Dauntless Vanguard since childhood, and First Shield above all, and while she was excited to join their august number, she was also anxious to prove herself to them.

They walked as one, garbed in full brightsteel armor, swords scabbarded at their hips and shields slung across their backs. They each carried heavy leather packs, bedrolls, waterskins, provisions, and equipment.

An outsider might not have recognized much to differentiate one soldier from another, other than the immense figure of the Stonehorn minotaur, Kriel. Cithria, however, having fought in the ranks of Ninth Battalion where uniformity was strictly enforced, saw that this elite Shield was allowed a little more freedom and individuality than the Ninth.

In the middle, Shield-Sergeant Merrek walked with the rolling gait of a sailor. He was the first of them she’d met, during the Testing. He seemed honest, forthright, and tough; not one to mince his words, but even-handed.

To Merrek’s left was Aiguo. Cithria had warmed to him instantly, with his wide, easy smile, and easy nature. He’d tried to make her feel comfortable from the off but, if anything, his nonchalant confidence had made her feel

even more self-conscious. As they walked across the dock, he was chattering away, keeping up a steady stream of observations and clever remarks.

Behind those two strode Alys Morn and the giant Stonehorn, Kriel. Morn made Cithria uneasy. She was serious and intense, and whenever that unsmiling gaze settled on her, Cithria felt like a day-one recruit once more.

It was tradition that the Dauntless Vanguard be always at full strength—sixteen complete companies, each consisting of sixteen Shields of eight soldiers. Usually, gaps were filled with soldiers of proven ability and discipline from within one of the other Vanguard battalions, but on occasion a recruit would be chosen directly from the training grounds, having displayed exceptional talent and potential. Alys Morn had been one such individual.

Viper-fast, and iron-strong, it was widely known that Morn was the best with a blade in First Shield—arguably the whole of the Dauntless Vanguard. She was almost as revered among the soldiery as the captain, and in truth, Cithria had idolized her since childhood. She had long dreamed of meeting her, but had not anticipated how intimidated she would feel.

Kriel on the other hand was a reassuring, grounded presence. He exuded calm, patience, and strength, and Cithria felt he was the real heart of First Shield.

The afternoon sun caught the threads of gleaming steel filling a number of nicks and clefts in his horns. As she understood it, they were marks of honor in Stonehorn culture, battle scars worn proudly.

“Why us?” said a voice, interrupting her thoughts. “Why send the *Vanguard* to check up on some old man hundreds of miles beyond the border?”

It was Eben Hess who spoke. He walked alone, scowling, a few steps behind Morn and Kriel.

While Cithria was intimidated by Alys Morn, she was positively unnerved by Hess. There was an unsettling coldness in his eyes, and he radiated danger, like an unsheathed blade.

“Maybe having you in the city makes people nervous, Hess,” said Saskja Vos.

Saskja and her twin brother, Rurik Vos, walked behind Eben Hess, just in front of Cithria. They were both powerfully built soldiers, with wide shoulders and thick arms, and they moved and spoke so similarly that they seemed sometimes like one person that had been split in two. Both had auburn hair, though Rurik’s was shorter, and they each had a smattering of freckles across their noses.

“Can’t say I blame them,” said Rurik. “Perhaps this is all—”

“Just a ploy—” continued Saskja.

“To get you far, far away,” finished Rurik.

In the short time she’d been around them, Cithria had come to realize it was common for the twins to complete each other’s thoughts, as if they always knew what was on the other’s mind.

“Would that we could be rid of him as easily,” said Alys Morn, from the front, making no attempt to remain unheard.

Eben Hess scowled.

“Just sayin’ it seems like any regiment could have done this,” he muttered. “Doesn’t seem like the time to be sending us away.”

“We all heard the same briefing you did, Hess,” said Merrek. “If you still don’t understand it, then just think of it this way: we are doing this because those are our orders. Nothing more complicated than that.”

“In the Ninth, we rarely got much of an explanation, let alone from our captain,” said Cithria, hoping she wasn’t speaking out of turn.

“Just one of the reasons why we’re lucky to have our sword-captain,” said Merrek, glancing back at her. “Most commanders do things by the book. They pass their orders down the chain of command, expecting no questions. Garen’s different.”

“I guess most commanders don’t feel it necessary to explain the reason behind their orders to every soldier under their command,” Cithria said.

“Soldiers are able to make better decisions on the field if they understand why they are doing what they have been ordered,” said Merrek. “The Vanguard are trained to fight in the most dangerous conditions, and face the worst the enemy can throw at us. If there is only one soldier left in the whole battalion, he wants to make sure they know how to achieve victory.”

Cithria nodded slowly, starting to understand, and as she did, her respect for Garen deepened. It made a lot of sense… even though she was sure Garen’s approach ruffled the feathers of some of the more traditional generals higher up.

“I’m just happy we are going by water,” said Merrek, with a grin. “Certainly beats marching.”

“Say that after you’ve been rowing for three days straight,” muttered Hess.

Cithria glanced at him warily.

All the members of First Shield had a sword and long-bladed knife strapped at their sides, but Eben Hess bore a number of additional blades, including a second sword and at least half a dozen more knives and daggers.

Clearly feeling her eyes upon him, Hess turned abruptly and glared at her,

his eyes wild.

“What’re you staring at?” he snarled at her.

“Er,” said Cithria, caught off guard. “That’s a lot of weapons.”

“There are few situations that can’t be solved with an extra blade,” he said. “Like gouging out over-inquisitive eyes.”

“Enough, Hess,” growled Merrek, and the soldier turned away from Cithria, falling into a brooding silence.

Cithria puffed out her cheeks, wondering what she had let herself in for. Aiguo gave her a wink.

They reached their vessel, having walked the rest of the way along the dock in silence. The ship was called the *Stormbright*, a falconship built to navigate shallow rivers as easily as the open ocean, and she was sleek as a blade. Thirty rowing benches were set down the inside of the pale hull like ribs, and oars were stacked in the bottom. Its figurehead was a white bird of prey, as was customary on all falconships, sharply angled forward and with wings spread wide.

First Shield clambered aboard, stowing packs under benches and claiming positions at the stern, to the rear of the vessel. Cithria stood on the dock, a little uncertain where to go, wary of inadvertently taking someone’s usual position. Kriel evidently felt her unease and ushered her onboard, pointing her toward a rowing bench close to the tiller. As Cithria got herself settled, Fourth and Eighth Shield marched down the dock and clambered aboard with a good amount of friendly banter and insults. Merrek nodded to the shield-sergeants leading those two units; the affable, supremely competent Reika Kol of Fourth, and the big, unsmiling brute Rosk of Eighth. While First and Fourth were armed with shields and swords—the traditional armament of the Demacian soldier—Eighth carried the immense

brightsteel kite shields commonly known as bulwarks. They were almost twice the size of a regular shield, such that only the largest soldiers were able to wield them effectively. Bulwark units formed impenetrable walls on the battlefield, as difficult to breach as the defenses of the capital itself. The soldiers of Eighth took their place at the prow, while those of Fourth took the benches in the middle.

Last to arrive was Garen, and the Vanguard quietened as he boarded, grim-faced and stern. He moved among the soldiers, addressing them by name, swapping a few words here and there, and slapping his hand upon pauldrons. Cithria marveled at how easy it seemed for Garen to connect with his soldiers, and the positive effect his presence had, even though his mood was clearly somber.

“We have three hours before sunset, and the skies are clear,” Garen said, moving down the length of the falconship. “I want us fifty miles from the capital before dark. Every soldier on an oar.”

“You heard the sword-captain!” shouted Merrek, and the Vanguard quickly untied the *Stormbright* from her mooring. Those on the leeward side of the dock, including Cithria, slipped their heavy oars into position, keeping the blades out of the water as those on the dockside pushed off, before they too set their oars.

Garen placed a hand on Merrek’s shoulder. “Take the tiller, old friend.”

“I’m not so old I can’t row,” grumbled Merrek, making Garen smile.

“You know the currents and tides better than anyone here,” he said. “And I’d like to row for a while.”

With a nod, Merrek gave up his bench for Garen. He had to squeeze past the massive figure of Kriel, who had seated himself centrally in the rear of the *Stormbright*, where he could row with an oar in each hand. Cithria

blinked in awe at the Stonehorn’s strength, as Merrek took the tiller.

“Vanguard!” Merrek roared. “Ready oars!”

Every soldier responded with guttural grunt, leaning forward in perfect synchronicity, their oars dipping deep.

“Pull!” bellowed Merrek.

The *Stormbright* shot forward like a spear, cutting through the water of the Ironfork River.

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Chapter Three

It took less than an hour to reach the Bay of Sentinels. They traveled with the river current, though the Ironfork widened and became evermore sluggish the closer they got to the sea. Once into the bay, the wind hit them, allowing them to draw in their oars and unfurl their sails. The autumn winds carried them on at good speed, the *Stormbright* slicing effortlessly through the choppy water as they angled south-east, hugging the coastline. They cut along below the immense white cliffs of Havenfall, salt spray whipping at them, and continued along the shore as it turned inland.

As twilight beckoned, the pale cliffs shifted through a series of brilliant hues, from pale orange to deep red, then to cold purples and blues as they lost the sun.

The wind urged the *Stormbright* onward with biting ferocity. Darkness descended as they passed across the narrowing Whitepoint Harbor, and as they turned into the Silverrun River, Merrek ordered oars extended once more, the wind having blown itself out.

They maintained a constant speed, the three squads rowing in shifts. First and Fourth Shield started, with the Eighth taking the opportunity to rest. Every two hours they rotated, with Fourth taking the next rest while Eighth and First rowed.

When it came time for First Shield to rest, the sickle moon had already risen high into the night sky. Cithria’s arms ached, and she gladly found a place to lie in the bottom of the hull, her head pillowed by her rolled-up blue cloak. The familiar stars overhead—the Guardian, the Judicator, and such—were momentarily blotted out as they passed beneath what Cithria

hazily recognized as the towering, graceful arches of the Bridge of Offerings. Then sleep claimed her. A soldier quickly learned to get rest when they could.

Nevertheless, it seemed like no time had passed at all when Kriel woke her with one giant hand on her shoulder. She was awake instantly, and nodded her thanks.

Garen, Cithria saw, was still at an oar.

“Have you not slept, sword-captain?” she asked.

Garen shook his head. “I’ll get a few hours before sunrise,” he added.

“Take the tiller for a while, at least,” said Merrek, from behind them. Garen looked set to refuse, then seemed to change his mind. He nodded to Cithria, and took over from Merrek.

The other members of First Shield took the oars from Eighth, and the *Stormbright* continued its journey onward, gliding silently along the mirror-smooth Silverrun. So still was the water, and so perfectly did it reflect the night sky, that it was almost impossible to tell where one finished and the other began.

Night slowly gave way to cold, pre-dawn light. They were far from the Great City now, deep in the verdant countryside, and the only sounds were the steady dip of oars, along with the occasional cry of a cockerel as the morning approached.

Rolling green hills rose to either side of the gently flowing river. Rocky outcrops of pristine white stone jutted from hillocks, and swathes of woodland butted up against foggy valleys divided into fields by dry stone walls. Huge shaggy oxen watched their passing, and a herdsman raised a hand in greeting from the south bank as the falconship slid silently by.

The *Stormbright’s* passing disturbed a family of otter-hawks, which

squawked in alarm as they burst from a patch of reeds, beaks snapping, before they slipped beneath the water.

By mid-morning, a breeze picked up, allowing the ship's sails to be unfurled, though Garen maintained the rotation of rowers, for the wind was not strong, and the captain was eager to press forward as fast as possible.

They were cheered as they passed by a farming village—Cithria didn't know its name—and young men and women tossed fresh apples and loaves of heavy, dark bread to them, along with garlands of flowers. It was Last Harvest, a regional feast day, and clearly the celebrations were already well under way. A bouquet landed in Alys Morn's lap as she rowed, and Cithria suppressed a laugh as the severe veteran raised an eyebrow at the blushing girl who had thrown it. Another hooked over one of Kriel's horns, making the giant guffaw with delight. Children ran along the banks, trying to keep pace with the *Stormbright*. The sun was shining, and the green splendor of the Demacian heartland spread in every direction.

"Remember, Vanguard, this is what we fight to protect," Garen said, gesturing around them. "Never forget that."

They rowed on through the day, keeping up a steady speed, and by early afternoon the jagged, tree-lined flanks of the Greenfang Mountains rose in the distance.

"Look, there!" said Cithria, pointing upward, squinting toward the peaks. "Raptors!"

There were a trio of them, high above, swirling and diving through the clouds. The cloaks of their riders trailed behind them as they coiled and rolled through the air, hundreds of feet overhead.

"I'd love to ride one of them, one day," Cithria said, wistfully. Eben Hess scoffed, but she ignored him. Not even his sourness could ruin her wonder.

“The land must look like a map laid out below them,” she said. “I wonder if they can see us?”

“They saw us long before we saw them,” said Garen.

As if to emphasize the point, the trio of raptors dove suddenly, tucking their wings and hurtling straight down toward their ship. The sunlight glinted off the riders’ armor and long lances as they plummeted. At the last moment, they pulled their mounts up, and the three raptors swept overhead, just feet above the tip of the *Stormbright’s* mast. They were big, of similar length to the ship itself, and their necks and tails were elegant and serpentine. The wind from their massive feathered wings buffeted the Vanguard, eliciting curses from Fourth Shield, who had been trying to sleep.

Cithria was filled with childlike wonder as the knights skimmed the river’s surface, trailing their back claws in the water, then gaining height once more with a few powerful beats of their wings.

“They’re amazing,” she breathed.

“They truly are,” said Kriel, leaning forward on his bench to direct Cithria’s gaze with an outstretched arm. “Beautiful, just like their home.”

As the *Stormbright* passed a bend in the river, several white-stoned fortresses and watchtowers built into the nearest peaks of the Greenfangs came into view.

“Behold Everpeak,” said the Stonehorn, his voice filled with admiration.

Cithria stared in wonder at the eyrie-fortress, high above. Slender arches of white stone connected its towers and spires, like graceful strands of spider web, and blue pennants fluttered in the thin mountain air at their tops, reaching higher than the Greenfangs’ tallest ridges.

She remembered her father’s tales of this place—how it was one of only a

handful of citadels in Demacia that was home to the raptor knights, and arguably the most important—but she'd never realized how majestic it would look.

"Its position overlooks the entire Greenfang Pass," said Kriel, "allowing the raptor patrols an unobstructed view all the way to the border."

"How were they able to build it that far up the mountain?" said Cithria. "Did they use the raptors to raise it?"

"Hah! No, they used *us*," said Kriel. "King Argostan commissioned my ancestors to build this fortress centuries ago. Many of Demacia's oldest fortifications were built by the master stonemasons of my people, all the way back to the Founding."

Cithria looked up for long minutes, entranced by the majestic beauty of the Everpeak, until Merrek's voice brought her back to the present.

"Expecting someone, captain?" said the shield-sergeant.

Cithria dropped her gaze and saw a stone jetty jutting into the flow at the base of the Greenfangs. A lone figure had emerged from the woods, stepping out to meet them, a large bird of prey clinging to one raised arm.

For half a second, Cithria thought she was looking at some branch-nymph or fae creature, for this woman seemed to have materialized out of the trees themselves. She pulled back the hood of her cloak, revealing stern features.

"Quinn," said Garen, with a hint of a smile—the first Cithria had seen from him since their departure.

****

Cithria tried not to look, but found her gaze kept returning to the lean, fierce-looking ranger-knight.

Quinn sat casually on the gunwale at the bow of the ship, one leg hugged

to her chest, the other dangling over the side as she stared out into the distance. Other than a brief, hushed conversation with Garen, she had not spoken, nor had she offered to take an oar.

Her striking amber eyes missed nothing, and she had caught Cithria staring at her more than once. Each time she did, Cithria looked quickly away, feeling awkward.

Cithria judged Quinn as one more comfortable alone in the wilds than in company, and her leather armor and boots were worn. Of her bird, there was no sign; she'd launched it into the air before she had jumped aboard the *Stormbright*. Doubtless it was somewhere unseen overhead.

An elegant repeater crossbow hung on her hip, along with a large knife, but she otherwise carried little more than crossbow bolts packed tightly in leather cases, and a water skin.

"No pack, see," hissed Eben Hess from an oar nearby, speaking in a low, dangerous voice. "Means she doesn't have any food with her. Probably expects to eat ours."

"She's a ranger," said Cithria. "I don't imagine finding food in the wilds would be difficult for her."

Hess grunted and kept rowing, glaring at Quinn. She stretched like a cat, seemingly without a care in the world, before lying back and closing her eyes. Cithria stared at her in admiration. One day, she hoped to have half the easy confidence the ranger-knight exuded. She would be willing to bet Quinn never doubted if she was worthy.

"Look at her, leaving all the rowing to us," snarled Hess. "Nice for some."

"Enough," said Shield-Sergeant Merrek, from his oar, nearby.

Cithria began counting silently under her breath, wondering how long it

would take Hess to make his next spiteful remark. Not long, as it turned out.

“Must be nice—”

“Keep your damn mouth shut, Hess,” Merrek snapped.

Hess glared at him, but stayed mercifully quiet.

Merrek winked at Cithria, who did her best to hide her smile, and they continued on up the Silverrun in silence.

****

Quinn heard every word, of course—her senses were far keener than the average person’s—and she suppressed a grin at the gray-beard sergeant’s shutdown of his man. She didn’t like people overmuch as a rule, but she instinctively trusted that shield-sergeant.

As a ranger, her heightened senses were a blessing, allowing her to hear a twig break underfoot hundreds of yards away or catch the scent of an approaching enemy on the wind, but sometimes—generally when she was around cityfolk—it felt like an affliction.

Every muttered curse, grunt, and belch on the ship assailed her ears, and the stink of sweat, oil, and leather was overpowering. Demacians, as a whole, prided themselves on their cleanliness, and even small villages boasted bathhouses, yet there was no way close to thirty soldiers could smell good after several days of hard rowing. The only one of them who didn’t stink, some might say ironically, was the Stonehorn.

Quinn turned her head away, into the breeze. Opening her eyes, she surveyed the riverbank, sliding past.

She didn’t care what the soldiers thought, and she wasn’t going to waste her time explaining herself. It wasn’t laziness that stopped her from taking an oar. They had no reason to know, nor any need to know, that she’d been

in the northern foothills when she'd received her orders. She'd run for two days straight, and through most of the previous night, to meet them here, so she'd take some sleep now, and be damned what they thought.

Once they got off this boat, there would be no rest for her until these soldiers were back safely within Demacia's borders. They were her charges now, her foul-smelling flock, and it was her duty to guide them safely.

A shadow crossed the sun far overhead, and she smiled. Valor was keeping watch. Just knowing he was up there was a comfort.

Quinn closed her eyes once more, and tried her best to blot out everything but the lapping of the river.

****

Cithria observed subtle changes in their surroundings as they neared the border.

Farms became fewer and further apart, replaced with an increasing number of watch posts as they rowed steadily east. Where the river narrowed at one point, they slid past a pair of squat towers, one on either bank, each manned by a garrison of soldiers. A huge chain, each link the size of a man's body, draped down under the water between the two towers.

"That chain can be cranked tight, to block invading ships, right?" said Cithria.

Shield-Sergeant Merrek nodded.

"Aye," he said. "It'd make a right mess of anyone that tried to get by it."

"Has it ever been needed?"

"No," said Merrek, "and I pray it never will."

A road paved with white stone ran alongside the southern bank—Founders Road—heading almost directly west, all the way to the capital,

following the same route taken by the kingdom’s first settlers.

The highest peaks of the Greenfangs were behind them now, and fortifications hove into view up ahead, just before the valley widened. Cithria knew this was Custodian Wall, the eastern edge of Demacia—a line of linked fortresses and bastions guarding Greenfang Pass.

With every stroke, the Vanguard expedition drew closer to the border. Huge, white-stoned towers rose on each bank, linked by massive arches spanning the river. The battlements were thick and sturdy, and patrolled by scores of soldiers. An immense iron portcullis closed off the river, blocking further progress. Nothing larger than an otter-hawk could squeeze through.

“Raise the Dauntless Standard,” ordered Garen, and the battalion’s banner, displaying the white-winged shield on a blue field, was hoisted to the top of the mast. After a few minutes, the grand portcullis blocking the river began to lift with a grinding of gears, dripping with weed.

Garen stood tall in the bow of the *Stormbright* as the Vanguard rowed through. The soldiers posted on the towers and walls above snapped to attention, saluting.

“Honor and glory!” one of them shouted.

Garen returned the salute, his expression stern.

Then they were through, and the portcullis crashed down behind them with a heavy splash.

They had left Demacia.

Various members of the Vanguard muttered prayers of protection and sanctity, paying homage to the Judicator, or whispering entreaties to the Veiled Lady. Eben Hess pressed a small petricite token of devotion to his lips, while Kriel gave honor to his ancestors, raising his right hand to his heart, his forehead, and the sky.

Cithria said a quiet prayer under her breath.

This was a routine journey, out and back, yet something about it made her uneasy.

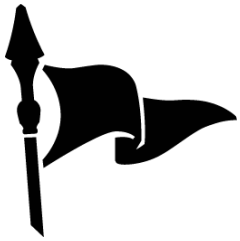
A shiver passed through Cithria, and she pulled her cloak tighter around her shoulders.

On they rowed, leaving home behind and passing into the wilderness of the Barrens.

Overhead, the sky darkened.

A storm was brewing.

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Chapter Four

Through pouring rain, the *Stormbright* glided along the Silverrun unchallenged, passing the rural farmland and untamed forests of the Arbormark, then on into the lands of the Skaggorn.

“They’re said to have come down from the Freljord and settled here generations back,” said Merrek as they took a wide arc past a Skaggorn settlement surrounded by a wooden palisade, complete with outward-facing stakes. “Apparently, they’ve long forsaken their raiding past, but you can never be too careful. There’s a little wolf in even the most docile dog.”

Cithria jumped as Eben Hess threw his head back and let loose a wild howl to the sky. He grinned savagely at her, clearly pleased in the fact he’d made her flinch.

Merrek shook his head, and glanced over at Cithria as she pulled on her oar. “You getting on alright, girl?” he said.

Cithria nodded. She was soaked through, as they all were, and her hands were blistered from rowing, but she wouldn’t allow herself to complain.

“Doing fine, sir,” she said.

“I’m as poor-born as they come, girl,” Merrek said. “You don’t need to ‘sir’ me. Sergeant is fine. Don’t need to be of noble birth to serve in the Vanguard, thank the heavens.”

The land became steadily wilder the further east along the Silverrun they traveled. The forests became thicker and more twisted, and the pristine white stone quarried in Demacia gave way to broody, dark shale.

Finally, after two days of travel through the relentless downpour, they reached a major fork in the river. They turned north-east, continuing up the

narrowing Silverrun, which was running faster and colder now that they drew nearer its source.

As the rain worsened and night fell once again, Garen ordered a halt. To proceed at night was risky, for it would be impossible to see rocks and fallen logs. Eighth Shield hauled the ship onto the shore, while the soldiers of First and Fourth established a defensive perimeter. Once the camp was in order, Merrek ordered a rotating watch. First Shield took the first shift, and the others quickly hunkered down to get some sleep, using the ship and its oiled sails for cover, while Quinn stalked off into the night.

Cithria startled awake an hour before dawn, and was reaching instinctively for her sword before she remembered where she was. As she lay there, breathing deeply to calm her racing heart, staring up at the darkness overhead, she realized there were people talking in hushed tones nearby.

“—worry that we’ve lost too much experience. She can’t replace that.”

That was Alys Morn. Cithria recognized her husky voice instantly. She didn’t feel comfortable overhearing what seemed to be a private conversation, so she closed her eyes, and tried not to listen.

“Helmar was First Shield for over a decade,” said another voice. Merrek. “Of course she can’t step into his shoes right away. It’s unfair to expect her to.”

Cithria went very still, realizing what was being discussed. The soldier they were talking about, Helmar, had been the Vanguard whose death had opened a place in First Shield… the place she had been brought in to fill.

“I would have been happier getting a veteran,” said Morn. “Cloudfield’s out of her depth. She might become a good fit in the future, but she’s not now.”

“I think she’ll surprise you,” said Merrek.

The two senior members of First Shield walked off into the darkness, out of earshot, but Cithria had heard enough.

She lay motionless, curled on her side. She’d been so excited to serve alongside First Shield, and Alys Morn in particular. To hear Morn express doubt about her readiness was like a punch in the guts.

Finally, knowing she wasn’t going to get any more sleep, Cithria sat up. She unstoppered her waterskin and took a sip. She knew she ought to eat something, for they had a strenuous march ahead, but her stomach was churning so much she doubted she would keep anything down.

Garen and several others were gathered nearby, talking in low voices. Seeing her awake, Merrek waved her over.

Somewhat reluctantly, feeling very small and out of place, she joined the group, which was gathered around a map unfolded on a large stone. Alys Morn was there as well, but Cithria kept her eyes down, hoping the darkness hid the blush of shame she felt on her cheeks.

The ranger-knight Quinn had returned, and she was gesturing to the map as Cithria joined them. All of them were damp, tired, and grim. Quinn was the only one who seemed unaffected by the weather. Her bird, on the other hand, looked particularly put out, sitting on a branch overhead, feathers ruffled, watching the goings-on below with unblinking eyes.

“There was little snow-melt over summer, and winter’s settling in early,” Quinn was saying. “The rivers coming down the northern mountains are lower than usual. Lots of exposed rocks. We won’t get further than the Gray Claws,” she said, indicating a section of the river on the map. “We should ditch the boat on the north bank at the tip of the Claws, and climb the ridge along here, through Rijenland territory. There’s a deep ravine dividing

Rijenland and the Nockmirch, at the bottom of which is the river—fast-flowing and dangerous, with dozens of falls—but there's a ford here," she said, now indicating a point on the map close to their destination. "It's quite the climb down and back up to Alderburg, but I'm sure the Vanguard can manage."

"Why not land on the Nockmirch side?" grunted Rosk of Eighth. "Would save us having to traverse that ravine."

Quinn shook her head. "This is all fenland," she said, indicating the Nockmirch side of the river. "You don't want to try to march through that mire. We *could* traverse around it, come to Alderburg from the east, but that would add two or three days."

"No," said Garen. "We do as you suggest. You're familiar with this land?"

Quinn nodded. "Traveled through here last winter. Rough terrain, heavily wooded on the Rijenland side. No settlements to speak of, just scattered cabins and villages. On the Nockmirch side, Alderburg sits atop the highest point above the ravine, here."

"Describe it," said Garen.

"It's the ancestral home of the rulers of the Nockmirch. The hillfort at the town's center is a good defensive position. It's not large, with a standing garrison of less than three hundred, but it's walled, and could hold a siege. Be difficult to take by force, if they knew you were coming. It's resisted more than a few Freljord war-parties raiding over the peaks, but the last attempt was more than a decade back. They're tough, Nockmirchers, but I fear they've gone soft without any threat for so long."

"Any trouble between the Nockmirch and Rijenland?" said Merrek. "Bad blood? Feuds?"

Quinn shook her head. “The occasional Nockmirch hunter caught on the wrong side of the river-border, but nothing serious. Their alliance has been strengthened over the generations through marriages and such.”

“How long will it take us to get to the Gray Claws?” asked Garen, looking to Merrek, as the most experienced boatman on board. The old sergeant frowned at the map.

“Not long. Less meltwater will mean an easier time rowing. If we head off at dawn, we should be there by mid-morning, I’d judge,” he said, looking to Quinn for her thoughts.

“Sounds about right,” she said. “I’ve scouted the route and didn’t see any river blockages that would slow our progress. Once we ditch the ship, it’ll be a day’s hard march to Alderburg.”

“We’ll be there before nightfall, then,” said Garen, nodding. “Ready the Shields. We leave at first light.”

Looking down, Cithria turned and walked back to pack up her bedroll and pack. In silence, her stomach still churning, she made ready for the day ahead.

****

The Vanguard maintained a swift pace as they climbed the wooded ridge rising above the Silverrun.

They’d disembarked from the *Stormbright* earlier in the day, and Quinn instantly disappeared into trees, like a shadow. Knowing she was ranging ahead allowed Garen to drive the Vanguard hard.

They followed a rough hunters’ trail, advancing in a loose column two soldiers wide. Only Kriel walked alone, frequently having to stoop beneath dripping branches that everyone else simply walked under.

Garen marched at the front of the column, setting the pace alongside Alys Morn, with the rest of First Shield just behind.

The rain was falling once more, but no one complained, not about the rain nor the punishing pace. This was what they trained for. Garen expected much of his Vanguard, but no more than he expected of himself. It was part of what they were known for: their ability to march or even run for days on end, covering hundreds of miles over the roughest terrain, and still be able to defeat an enemy at the end of it. If there was a military force anywhere in Valoran or beyond that was better trained, fitter, or more disciplined, he'd never seen nor heard of it.

The rains gave way to a drizzling mist, and a damp fog that hung in the air, making the forest seem ethereal and ghostly. Garen could hear the river down the ravine to his right, crashing over the rocks far below, but visibility was limited.

He felt tense. The terrain reminded him of the recent weeks of chasing shadows through the Demacian wilderness, on constant alert for ambushes. The months of running battle against Sylas and rogue mages in the forests and marshes of Demacia kept him on edge.

Garen had Judgment half drawn as a figure materialised before him like a wraith, stepping out of the trees on the high side of the path.

"Damn it, ranger," hissed Alys Morn, shoving her own blade back into its sheath. "You have to sneak around like that?"

Quinn's expression was hard.

"What is it?" said Garen.

"We have a problem," said Quinn.

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Garen’s expression was grim as he stood on the edge of the deep ravine, looking northward.

Ahead, a fortified bridge of dark stone crossed the expanse, spanning the near-vertical drop down to the waterfalls and river far below. The stone was pristine and unmarked by the passage of time—it was plain the construction of the bridge had only recently been completed. Beyond it rose the settlement and hillfort of Alderburg, the seat of power of the Nockmirch.

Garen’s eyes were drawn to the soldiers atop the bridge’s guardtowers and Alderburg’s walls.

“This was not here at the start of summer,” said Quinn.

“Certainly makes crossing easier,” remarked Merrek.

“It does,” said Quinn. “The ravine path is not an easy one to navigate, and certainly not one you could lead a horse down.”

“Whereas an entire army could march across that bridge—” said Garen.

“—in a matter of hours,” finished Quinn.

They stepped away from the edge of the ravine, back into the cover of the trees, where the three Shields waited silently.

“I would think the construction of a bridge of that scale would be something our ambassador in the Nockmirch might have mentioned in his dispatches,” said Garen.

“One would think,” agreed Quinn.

“Orders, sword-captain?” said Shield-Sergeant Rosk.

“Unchanged,” said Garen. “I think it is time we meet the Lord of the Nockmirch, and see what has become of our ambassador.”

****

A road had recently been constructed on the Rijenland side of the ravine,

leading toward the bridge. Whoever had built the bridge had felled trees and leveled the ground, creating an arrow-straight path leading directly west.

“If there are no settlements of any size for fifty miles that way,” said Merrek, furrowing his brow as he pointed behind the Vanguard party, “why bother with all this?”

Cithria could understand why Garen’s expression darkened as they turned onto the new road and approached the bridge. It was a formidable example of military architecture—for there was no denying it was built with defense in mind.

A squat gatehouse loomed over either side of the ravine, complete with battlements and portcullis. Their design was foreign to Cithria, ugly, angular, and hostile in appearance to her eyes, but they were undeniably well built and strong. A stone rampway led up to the closest gatehouse. Above, she could see flags of pale gray, bearing black heraldry of a spiked portcullis.

The bridge itself was wide enough for ten soldiers to march abreast, and its sides were crenellated, like a fortress wall, in the same blocky style of the gatehouses. The Vanguard instinctively closed ranks, tightening their formation as they advanced along the road.

If there were any Nockmirch sentries, they were not particularly attentive, Cithria noted, for no one appeared to have seen the Vanguard’s approach. Such laxness would never be tolerated within Demacian ranks. They were within fifty yards of the gatehouse before anyone spotted them.

“Halt! Who goes there?” came the belated challenge from atop the gatehouse. To Cithria’s ears, the man spoke with an oddly lilting accent.

Garen raised his hand, and the Vanguard stopped in perfect unison.

“Sword-Captain Garen Crownguard of Demacia,” he hollered.

“You have business in the Nockmirch?”

“Unless I am mistaken, we are not in the Nockmirch,” replied Garen, his voice hardening. “This side of the Silverrun is Rijenland. I might ask what business you have fortifying a position here? Some might see that as an act of aggression against an ally.”

The guard seemed flustered, unsure exactly how to respond. He conferred with the other guards on the tower.

“Wait there,” he shouted, finally. “I’ll get the warden.”

****

Garen was not sure who he was expecting; an officious bureaucrat, or an aging, fat gatekeeper long past his prime, perhaps. He was certainly not expecting the veteran soldier who came to meet him.

The warden introduced himself as Vigrid, and he assessed Garen with intelligent eyes. There was a slight accent behind his Nockmirch lilt, some regional variation Garen wasn’t aware of.

His skin was as pale as snow, as was his cropped hair, and he looked like a fighter, with a square jaw and a nose that had clearly been broken more than once. In his dark plate armor he was half a head taller than Garen, and a pale gray cloak hung over his shoulders, held in place with a silver portcullis pin: the symbol of the Nockmirch. He carried no weapons, but walked with a warrior’s confidence.

Warden Vigrid had the stern bearing of a military commander, someone used to his orders being carried out without question. He would not have seemed out of place in the upper echelons of command in Demacia.

“My apologies for leaving you and your soldiers waiting, captain, particularly in this weather,” said Vigrid. “The Lord Castellan of the

Nockmirch insists on being personally notified of all arrivals to Alderburg… but also that his afternoon respite not be interrupted."

He was clearly embarrassed and more than a little exasperated by the demands of his lord. Garen suppressed a wry smile. Some things remained the same, wherever you went.

"A little rain does not concern us," he assured the warden.

Vigrid squinted up at the dark sky, rain splattering against his face.

"When I was a lad, dreaming of joining the military," he said, "I never realized how much of my time would be spent standing around in the mud, waiting on the nobility."

"The soldier's life," remarked Garen.

"Indeed," said Vigrid. He indicated across the bridge with a nod. "Come. A room has been prepared for you in the keep, and we've cleared out one of our barracks for your soldiers."

Garen fell into step alongside the warden as he led them through the guard tower and onto the bridge, with the rest of the Vanguard close behind.

"Thank you," said Garen, "though I will billet with my soldiers."

Vigrid nodded, as if expecting that. "I would do the same," he said.

Garen found himself studying the bridge's defenses. Oddly, the guard tower seemed designed to hold against enemies coming from either side, rather than just from the Rijenland. Normally, such towers were designed to have a strong outward face, but not be defensible from the rear, so as not to give an enemy a strong position if it fell. This tower seemed more like a fortress in its own right than just a gateway to Alderburg. Strange.

"This is newly constructed," noted Garen. "Are you expecting trouble?"

Vigrid sighed. "The lord castellan sees trouble everywhere, since the death of his wife."

Garen frowned. “The death of his wife?”

Vigrid nodded grimly. “She passed just before the season began to turn. The wasting sickness. Took her within days.”

“I am truly sorry to hear that,” said Garen.

The roar of the falls far below echoed around them, and clouds of rising water-spray filled the air.

“But enough of such talk,” said Vigrid, as they crossed the bridge. “You’re a long way from home. What brings you to our little backwater?”

“A matter of state,” said Garen. “I need to speak with your lord, if that could be arranged?”

“A welcome banquet is being prepared in the great hall, in your honor,” he said. “You will be able to address your matter of state with the lord castellan then.”

“A banquet,” Garen said, without enthusiasm.

“The nobility has a certain way they like to do these things. Drink, food, terrible music, and inane smalltalk all come before business.” Vigrid glanced over at him as they walked, a hint of a smile on his lips. “Be thankful you did not arrive during the equinox, else there would have certainly been dancing.”

They reached the other side of the bridge, passing through a second fortified gatehouse and into the walled town of Alderburg proper. The keep loomed above them, built atop a great, rocky mound. Garen glanced back across the Vanguard ranks, catching Quinn’s eye. The ranger-knight was walking at the back of the column, her cloak drawn tight around her shoulders, and her bird nowhere to be seen. She gave him an almost imperceptible nod.

Garen and the Vanguard followed the Nockmirch warden toward the

barracks, passing dozens of humble, turf-roofed homes. People watched their passing from shadowed doorways. He heard no laughter, even among the children. The lord’s wife must have been well loved.

The Nockmirch was not a wealthy nation, judging by the way these townsfolk lived. But then, where had the money to build that bridge come from?

When next Garen glanced back, Quinn was nowhere to be seen.

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Chapter Five

I don’t like this,” snarled Eben Hess.

He was pacing back and forth in the narrow space between the bunk beds like a caged animal, fists clenched.

“We know,” said Saskja Vos from where she sat on her bunk, sharpening her sword.

“You’ve been saying that for the last hour,” added her twin, Rurik, who sat on the bunk opposite his sister, also sharpening his blade.

Cithria lay on a hard pallet atop her bunk, staring at the low, roughly hewn ceiling above. Absently, she reached out to touch the stone. It was slightly damp, and bone cold.

Each of the three Shields had been given a chamber within the barracks at the foot of the hill below the keep. More than half the building was underground, the rooms carved from the rock below the keep itself, including the three in which the Demacians had been billeted.

Of First Shield, only Cithria, Hess, and the twins were here in the barracks at the moment, however. Garen had chosen Merrek, Morn, Kriel, and Aiguo to accompany him to the banquet in the great hall, along with two soldiers from each of Fourth and Eighth Shield.

“I don’t trust that warden,” said Hess. “Bastard made my skin crawl.”

Cithria didn’t know what he was talking about. It seemed to her that Garen and the warden had gotten along well enough, and if the sword-captain approved of him, then who was she to judge differently?

“He seemed fine to us,” said Saskja. “And it’s usually you—”

“—who makes others feel uncomfortable,” completed Rurik. “So now

you know—”

“—how everyone else feels all the time.”

Cithria could hear the mocking smile in their voices. She peered over the edge of the bunk, scarcely daring to breathe. Hess’ expression was dark. She wondered how much of the twins’ goading it would take before he cracked. Saskja and Rurik kept sharpening their swords, not even glancing up, though she thought there was a hint of the same smirk mirrored on their faces.

“There’ll be blood spilt before we leave this place, mark my words,” Hess said.

The door to the room opened suddenly, and an unfamiliar figure stepped in. Hess lunged at the newcomer with a snarl, blade drawn instantly.

It was a Nockmirch soldier—a boy really, Cithria saw—and he was bearing a pitcher and stack of cups. He gave a strangled shout as he saw Hess coming at him, and promptly dropped everything he was carrying. The pitcher smashed on the floor, spreading its sweet-smelling contents across the stone, and cups went rolling in every direction.

Hess sheathed his blade, with a curse. “Feels like a damned tomb in here,” he snarled. “I’m going to get some air.”

He pushed the terrified boy out of his way, and stalked out of the room, into the night.

“Don’t hurry back,” Rurik said.

“I’m… I’m sorry,” said the Nockmirch boy, as he started to gather up his dropped cups. “I was just sent to bring you some mead.”

“You’re fine,” said Cithria, hopping off her bunk to help clean up the mess. She gave the boy a reassuring smile, and he practically fled from the room, mumbling something about fetching a mop.

“Is Hess always like that?” asked Cithria, stooping to pick up an errant cup.

“Only when he’s in a good mood,” smiled Saskja.

****

Garen sat at the high table, upon a raised dais at the head of the great hall. Heavy platters of food, piled with mutton, game hen, root vegetables, and bread, were placed liberally across the table. Garen ate only sparingly. He’d not had an appetite for weeks.

The majority of those present—the lesser nobility of the Nockmirch—ate at three long tables below. The Vanguard acting as Garen’s honor guard were seated down there as well, given places at the table closest to Garen.

There were five place settings at the high table, though only four were occupied. Eldwyn, Lord Castellan of the Nockmirch sat at its center, with his daughter, Lady Odelyn, to his left. Garen had been given the place of honor to the lord’s right, with Warden Vigrid beside him. He felt a certain amount of solidarity with the warden, who seemed as bored and uncomfortable as he did. Of the Demacian ambassador, Garen’s Great-Uncle Hargold, there was no sign, and the old lord castellan had waved off his questions thus far.

Despite the quantity of food and drink present, the banquet was a somber affair, with the Nockmirch in mourning.

It was a dark time for those of royal blood, it seemed. Garen felt his jaw clench, and forced himself to take a breath, to ease his rising tension.

The fire-blackened branches of thorn bushes adorned the tables and hung around the windows, as seemed to be the local custom. The lord and his daughter had blackened the top half of their faces with charcoal as a sign of

mourning, and their hair was powdered with ash. To Garen, they looked barbaric and otherworldly. The hall's musicians played only doleful songs, bereft of cheer.

"On behalf of Demacia, please accept my deepest condolences," Garen said. "And I apologize that no official message was sent. Word of your loss has not reached Demacia."

"Would it have made a difference?" said the Lord of the Nockmirch, looking up from his plate. His eyes were red-rimmed and bitter.

Garen knew Eldwyn was of a similar age to the late King Jarvan III—indeed, they had been battle-brothers and friends in their youth—but where the king had been full of vitality and strength until his dying day, this lord seemed old and hunched. It was as if all the joy and light in his world had been snuffed out, leaving just bile and resentment.

"I will carry word back, regardless," said Garen, feeling awkward. He had no experience dealing with grieving dignitaries, and was unsure of the required etiquette. "I am sure the prince will wish to send his condolences."

The lord castellan grunted and turned his attention back to his meal. He ate delicately, using his knife and fork like a field surgeon, but drank his wine eagerly. His goblet was hastily refilled by an anxious-looking server. Lord Eldwyn had emptied several glasses already, much, it seemed, to his daughter's displeasure.

"Thank you, sword-captain, and please forgive my father," said Lady Odelyn. "This has been a… trying time for us."

As Lady Odelyn spoke, Garen saw her glance toward the warden, and thought he saw a flash of something—anger? resentment?—in her eyes. Then the moment was gone, and he wondered if he had imagined it.

"And I would reiterate our condolences to Demacia, as well," continued

Lady Odelyn. “The fall of King Jarvan was a terrible shock. He was loved and respected here in the Nockmirch.”

Garen nodded his thanks.

Lady Odelyn was the Lord of the Nockmirch’s only child, and she bore herself with strength and confidence. Garen guessed she was of a similar age to his sister, though Lady Odelyn was as dark-featured as Lux was light. Garen pushed thoughts of his missing sister out of his mind. He could not afford to be distracted.

“I studied your king’s battles in my youth,” added Warden Vigrid. “He was a formidable warrior and, from what I understand, an honorable man and ruler.”

The warden raised his glass in salute.

A servant made to fill Garen’s goblet with wine, but he put his hand over it. “Just water, please,” he said.

“I hear it was a mage who killed my old friend,” said the lord castellan. “I take it the perpetrator was caught? It would be quite the stain on Demacian honor if they were not. Very embarrassing. They have been brought to justice, yes?”

By the cruel glint in the old man’s eyes, it was obvious he knew otherwise.

“He will be,” said Garen.

The lord castellan grunted.

An awkward silence settled on the high table, and Garen cast his eye around the hall. Guards were posted near, standing behind the high table, as well as at intervals around the room’s circumference, and at its doors. No one else in the great hall was armed, including the Vanguard, though the Demacians all wore their armor in lieu of suitable formal attire. Garen was

acutely aware of the absence of his weapon, left back at the barracks with their other weapons.

He found his gaze returning to the empty place setting for Great-Uncle Hargold. Before he could push the matter of his whereabouts, the lord castellan spoke again.

“So you saw my new bridge,” he said, glancing sideward at Garen. “Well, what do you think? How does it match up to those in mighty Demacia?”

Garen didn’t like the old man’s tone, and took another breath before he answered, refusing to let his irritation get the better of him.

“In honesty, lord castellan, I am confused as to its purpose,” said Garen, keeping his tone as neutral as possible.

“You are confused as to the purpose of a bridge?” snorted Lord Eldwyn, fastidiously wiping his hands clean with a silk napkin before tossing it to the floor. “Are you slow in the head, captain?”

Garen struggled to contain his anger as color rose to his cheeks. He was not here to trade barbs with foreign lords.

“It is built as a fortification,” said Garen, “yet the Nockmirch has only allies to the west.”

“It was built to aid trade with Rijenland, and beyond. But regardless, I would have thought you would want your allies strong. Able to defend themselves from attackers, yes?”

“You *have* no enemies to the west.”

“So I take it Demacia would prefer us to remain weak then, yes? More servile? Less like an ally more like… a servant? A dog begging for scraps?”

At those words, Lady Odelyn dropped her fork with a clatter.

“Enough, father!” she hissed. “Demacia has been our ally for centuries!”

“And yet they are never here when we need them!” snapped the Lord of

the Nockmirch. The hall fell into silence.

“Perhaps it would be worth—” said Warden Vigrid, clearly trying to ease the tension, but he was interrupted by Lady Odelyn.

“Do not speak, snake!” she snapped, jabbing a finger toward him, her cheeks flushed.

“Be silent, girl,” quivered Lord Eldwyn, his face bright red.

Garen mouthed a curse under his breath. They were all crazy. He longed for the clarity of a battlefield.

Odelyn rose to her feet, glaring over her father at Warden Vigrid. “Mother would never have allowed this worm to—”

“Speak not of your mother!” barked Lord Eldwyn, standing sharply and sending his high-backed chair crashing to the floor.

Every eye in the hall was locked on the lord and his daughter. No one seemed quite sure how to react.

“You try my patience, girl,” hissed Lord Eldwyn. “Guards, escort my daughter to her room. And see that she remains there.”

For a moment, it seemed that Odelyn was going to strike her elderly father, but then she cast one last hateful look at the warden, turned on her heel, and stormed from the room, followed by a sheepish-looking pair of guards.

Once she had gone, Lord Eldwyn sank back into his seat, and drained his goblet. The hall had fallen completely silent. Eldwyn glared around at the staring faces, and slapped his hand down hard on the table, making the cutlery and plates jump—as well as more than a few of his guests.

“Eat!” he ordered. “Drink!”

He gestured impatiently for the musicians to start up their dirge again, and one by one the people in the hall returned to their meals. Slowly, the

hum of conversation resumed.

Garen snuck a look at the warden beside him. Vigrid caught Garen's glance.

"Nobles," the warden said under his breath, shaking his head.

They ate in silence, Garen wishing he was anywhere but here.

Finally, the Lord of the Nockmirch spoke again.

"If the purpose of your visit is not to offer condolences, Demacian," he said, "then why *are* you here? Merely to stir up trouble?"

"I am here to see the Demacian ambassador," Garen said, his voice hard. He was done with this man and his lack of respect. "If something has happened to him, it would be in your best interest to tell me. Now."

****

Dusk was settling over the land as Quinn knelt upon the wet, loamy earth. The ground was churned and muddied by countless converging tracks. Cloven hoof marks, heading both east and west, marked this dip as being used by shepherds, but sheep wouldn't rip up the earth like this. No, this was the mark of a large company of men moving through the area—within the last few days, judging by the tracks.

She moved to the edge of the mire, frowning. After a time, she found what she sought—the clear outline of a boot. The indentation was deep.

"Heavy armor," she said to herself.

Quinn straightened, scanning the land around her.

She was some two miles out from Alderburg, which rose in the far distance, its keep silhouetted against the dying light. Pinpricks of orange light appeared one by one within the walled town as its people lit fires and lanterns for the evening. More lights dotted the wilderness beyond the

settlement, marking a handful of farmsteads. Scattered pockets of woodland and ancient stones created shadows in the landscape, and to the north lay a great swathe of darkness—a deep forest draped over hills that rose to the mountains in the north.

The obvious explanation for the tracks was Nockmirch soldiers returning to Alderburg, but from what Quinn had observed, the soldiers of this land did not wear heavy armor; most wore simple leathers or padded gambesons. None of them would have left such a deep bootprint in the mud. That soldier could have been burdened, of course, but the churned earth suggested that a considerable body of troops had passed this way. It was not just some small patrol.

A keening cry sounded from above, and Quinn extended an arm. Valor landed amid a flutter of wings, his talons closing around her leather-encased forearm. He regarded her with golden eyes, so like her own, turning his head first to one side, then the other.

“Getting hungry, Val?” she said, reaching out and ruffling the cobalt feathers behind his head. His eyelids dipped, and his talons flexed in pleasure. Then he pulled away, clacking his beak. “Okay, fine,” she said, throwing him back into the air. “Go hunt.”

Quinn followed Valor as he rapidly gained altitude and flew north. As she lost him in the dusk, her gaze settled on the dark forest once more. Something about that forest tugged at her. She was rapidly losing the light, but had long ago learned to trust her instincts. Nodding to herself, she set out up the hill toward the line of trees in the distance.

As she neared the forest’s edge, there was a streak of movement to her right. Valor dropped like a silent thunderbolt, hurtling down from above. Talons flashed, and a squeal of terror erupted from the undergrowth, though

it was quickly cut short. Quinn continued on. Pausing at the treeline, she saw Valor perched in the dead branches of a twisted, old tree nearby, beak and talons glistening with blood. A lifeless hare was draped across the branch beneath one claw.

“A good catch, brother,” said Quinn, giving Valor a nod.

With that, she turned and entered the forest.

Now it was her time to hunt.

****

“They seem like a nice, close family, don’t they?” mumbled Alys Morn, indicating toward the dais with a tilt of her head.

“Very,” said Merrek. He was making a pretense of eating, but hardly touched his food, nor his mead. “I hear the lord’s wife was the real strength in the Nockmirch. Perhaps it was she who held this lot together.”

“Typical,” said Morn, her scarred lips curling.

Merrek eyed the soldiers around the room, standing statue-still, leaning on halberds. “The guards look tense,” he said, under his breath.

“Agreed,” Morn said.

A glance along the table assured him that all the other members of the Vanguard were alert, though they were making a show of relaxing, eating, and drinking. That probably wouldn’t fool many, but the general opinion of Demacians being stuffy and prideful might, for once, serve them well. If anyone noticed them being on edge, they would likely put it down to their arrogance.

The only exception was Kriel, who was laughing uproariously, surrounded by a little cluster of children—the youngest of the Nockmirch’s nobility.

“Why don’t you eat any meat?” one of the children asked, pointing at Kriel’s plate, where he’d clearly eaten around the gravy-ladled mutton and beef he’d been served.

“This is your cousin, yes?” replied Kriel, pointing to a little boy staring at him with wide eyes. “Would you eat *him*?”

The kids all squealed, screwing up their faces. “No!” cried the girl who had asked him the question. “Yuck!”

“It would be the same for me!” said Kriel, laughing. “And see these teeth?” He leant forward, opening his mouth up wide. The children peered in, eyes wide in wonder and more than a hint of excited fear. Kriel snapped his teeth shut, making them jump. “My teeth are not made to eat meat!”

“At least someone is enjoying themselves,” said Morn, taking the smallest of sips of her mead.

“Still no sign of the ambassador,” said Merrek in a quiet voice.

****

Quinn crouched unmoving in the undergrowth, her position hidden by shadow and branches. Rain pattered around her, soaking her to the skin, and making the leaves tip and flutter.

As wet as she was, she was thankful for the downpour. It helped her, sending ripples of movement through the forest, and deadening all sound.

Her eyes were narrowed, staring intently at an indistinct shape up ahead. It looked like a rock, but she was sure she’d seen it move a few minutes earlier. So she waited, ignoring the unpleasant sensation of cold water rolling down her neck. A large, black slug oozed across one of her hands, but still she remained motionless, resisting the urge to flick it away.

Patience was a weapon as powerful as any blade.

At last, her dedication was rewarded. The ‘rock’ pushed back its hood, wiping rain from its face, and adjusted its position. Once the sentry fell still once more, it was time for Quinn to move.

This was not the first warrior she had seen within the forest. She had passed two others so far, and while she still didn’t know who they were, one thing she was sure of—whoever was hiding in this forest, they were no fools. It had taken all of Quinn’s skill to avoid them, slipping through their lines unseen.

These were not sentries half-heartedly dozing through their watch duties. They were alert and vigilant. Disciplined. And they were definitely not soldiers of the Nockmirch.

As she crawled up the hillock to move by this latest sentry, remaining unseen through the undergrowth, she got a good look at him.

Dark-featured and dark-eyed, he wore leather and heavy furs, and his flesh was tattooed with swirling patterns. He had a heavy bow resting across his lap, wrapped loosely in leather to keep the string dry.

In her time serving as a ranger-knight, Quinn had spent considerably more time outside Demacia’s borders than within. She spoke a dozen languages, had lived among the lowland tribes of the Freljord, and prided herself in knowing all the clans, nations, and states within a hundred leagues of Demacia… and yet she could not place this archer. Her best guess was that he was a barbarian tribesman of the distant eastern mountains, but that was far, far away, almost on the other side of the continent. What was he doing here in the Nockmirch, and what did his presence mean? Nothing good, she decided.

Half a mile further on, past three more vigilant sentries, she found their encampment. Quinn sucked in a deep breath, eyes widening as she

glimpsed its scale. It filled the entire hollow below her position.

Scores of warriors gathered around dozens of bonfires, packed in against the leeside of a rocky escarpment below, out of the worst of the rain and wind. Quinn saw that these were warriors drawn together from different regions, for their appearance was wildly divergent. Some were of the same culture as the sentries she'd already encountered, while others were giants among men, massive bearded warriors bedecked in heavy black iron, who roared and laughed, their language as harsh and bellicose as their appearance. Another group, one that seemed to keep itself apart from the rest, bore blood-red warpaint upon their faces and shaven heads, while yet others wore their hair in long, matted clumps, and had filed their teeth to points.

Quinn heard snippets of half a dozen different languages being spoken in this war camp. To bring such different cultures together, and unify them, took considerable skill—or power.

She noted as well that there were none of the usual hangers-on that traveled with a military force on the march—no hawkers, no families, no scavengers.

This was a war party.

Deeper in the camp, she glimpsed some shadowed beast, chained between trees. At first she thought it was a stand of boulders, but as it shifted its weight, she realized she was mistaken. The creature, whatever it was, was *huge*…

A branch cracked to Quinn's right, and she cursed, swinging around. The wind and rain that obscured her own footfalls also concealed those of the enemy. One of the giant outlanders had stepped out of the firelight to relieve himself. They locked eyes for a moment, and he drew breath to roar

a warning, scrabbling for his blade. A bolt from Quinn's crossbow silenced his shout before it could form. Blood bubbled from the shaft embedded in his throat and he dropped to one knee, even as he yanked his heavy, two-handed blade free. To Quinn's surprise, he pushed himself upright, staggering toward her with blood streaming down his black iron armor, eyes burning in hatred. He took two more bolts before he finally fell, collapsing face-first into the mud.

A questioning shout came from nearby, and Quinn cursed again. It was time to leave.

She turned, scrambling down through the undergrowth, trying to find a good balance between speed and stealth.

She came upon one of the sentries, who was still watching the approach to the war camp. There was no time to pass him without being seen.

Quinn drew her hunting knife and ghosted up behind him. Unnoticed, she cut his throat, and lowered him to the ground. Then she was off and moving once again, running in a low crouch. She heard a shout behind her. The body of the first warrior she'd killed had been found. More voices echoed through the forest and, glancing back, she saw warriors tromping down the ridge toward her.

Quinn broke into a sprint, all semblance of stealth abandoned, ducking branches and weaving in between trees. She leapt a fallen log, and spied another sentry, rising to her right. A crossbow bolt through his eye socket saw him falling back into the undergrowth, and Quinn raced on, moving with the speed of a hunting wolf… except now *she* was the one being hunted.

A sodden shape reared up amid a stand of rocks up ahead, arrow nocked to a bow swinging in her direction. A shadow streaked down from above,

moving fast. There was a strangled cry as Valor struck, dagger-like talons and curved beak raking and tearing. The sentry's arrow loosed blindly, flitting into the darkness, and the man dropped his bow, desperately trying to protect his eyes.

"Thank you, brother," Quinn said, breathlessly.

An arrow struck a tree close by, the shaft shuddering, and Quinn cursed quietly. It was pure luck she hadn't been hit. She set off again and instantly veered to her right, cutting through the trees at a different angle.

She burst through a thicket and threw herself forward into a roll. An arrow sliced the air just above her, missing her by scant inches. She fired as she rose to her feet, her momentum keeping her moving, and the archer dropped.

She sighted two more up ahead, alerted by the shouts now ringing out through the trees.

She felt Valor's presence over her shoulder.

"I'll take the one on the right! That one's yours," she called out, gesturing.

Valor screeched in response and shot forward. His beating wings had a span of over twelve feet, but that did not hinder him. He scythed through the trees, weaving and diving, tucking his powerful pinions in close between beats, angling inexorably toward his target. The sentry saw Valor coming, and hastily loosed an arrow at the deadly bird, but the shot missed its mark, disappearing harmlessly into the undergrowth.

Quinn used the terrain to her advantage, keeping the trees and rocks between her and her enemy as best she could, making herself a difficult target. The sentries' positions had been chosen for their commanding views south, not north, and her approach was well protected. An arrow skidded off

the rocks near her, and she heard a hiss of frustration.

The other archer screamed in shock and pain. Valor had found his target.

Quinn scrambled up the stand of rocks, then leapt lightly off the top of a large, moss-covered boulder. Turning in the air, she came down behind her enemy, who cursed and tried to bring his bow to bear. Quinn put two bolts in him, then she was moving once more.

Unlike a regular crossbow, Quinn's repeater was fed by a small, spring-loaded magazine. She didn't need to pause to reload.

Glancing over her shoulder, she could see scores of torches now moving through the forest.

It hadn't been her intention, but she'd kicked the hornet's nest this night.

It was possible the Lord of the Nockmirch had no idea there was a warhost camped mere hours from his doorstep. Possible, but unlikely.

A more reasonable explanation was that he knew full well he was harboring these warriors, concealed just out of sight; that he was doing so knowingly, and trying to conceal that from Demacia.

What's more, she now realized who they were…

She had to get word to Garen.

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Chapter Six

Ambassador Hargold, welcome back," said Lord Eldwyn. "Look who has come to pay you a visit. I fear the captain was just starting to believe something untoward had happened to you."

Garen stared at the newly arrived figure, who climbed the stairs to the high table. It had been many years since he'd seen Hargold, his grandmother's younger brother. Garen had been no more than a child when he had last come to Silvermere. His great-uncle was older now, of course, his golden hair having given way to white, and his soldier's physique considerably more frail, but Garen recognized him, nonetheless.

Garen rose to his feet, his expression clearly one of surprise.

"You look shocked, captain," said the lord castellan. "Did you really think something had happened to your precious ambassador?"

"No, I…" said Garen, still staring at Hargold. After seeing Tianna so concerned, he had been certain something had befallen him, but here he was, old but in good health. "It's just been such a long time," Garen said, trying to cover his surprise. He'd never been a good liar, however, and his face flushed.

"I look old, I know," said Hargold, with a kindly smile.

"The wolf stalks the shadows, waiting for us all," said the warden. "You probably look older to him as well, captain."

Garen nodded vaguely as his great-uncle approached him. Yes, he remembered his stiff, square shoulders, and those eyes that were so similar to his mother's, and his own. He saluted, for Hargold had held the position of marshal before he retired from the ranks and took up his diplomatic

position.

“It’s good to see you, my boy,” said Hargold.

****

“So the ambassador is fine, all is well,” said Aiguo. He flashed his fellow Vanguard a grin, and raised his empty goblet, calling for it to be refilled. “Long way to come for a family reunion, but since we’re here, might as well have another drink or two, eh?”

Merrek reached across the table and put a hand over Aiguo’s goblet, pushing it back to the table.

“No more drinking,” he said. “Something’s going on.”

****

“Apologies for not being here to greet you earlier, my boy,” said Hargold. “I have been somewhat unwell of late.”

“I am sorry to hear that, great-uncle,” said Garen. “Strength through discipline.”

“Yes, yes, indeed,” said Hargold.

Garen furrowed his brow. That was not the response he’d expected.

“I’m sure you two have much to catch up on,” said Warden Vigrid, standing from his place at the high table. “Please, ambassador, take my chair.”

The old man nodded his thanks, and Vigrid took a seat—somewhat reluctantly, it seemed—alongside the sour-faced lord castellan. Hargold sat, with Garen’s aid, and let out a loud sigh.

“It’s always a pleasure to see family, but I do I hope you didn’t march all the way out here just to check on me?” said the ambassador. “A simple

letter would have served."

"The High Marshal wanted me to come in person," said Garen.

"The High Marshal?"

"Aunt Tianna," said Garen. "She was… concerned."

"Well, nothing to be concerned about, as you can see," said the ambassador. "Just recovering from a bout of the shivers. I'm feeling much better, but I was told to stay abed for a few more days." He leaned conspiratorially close to Garen, and gave a wink. "Truth be told, the physiker is older than I am, and not nearly as learned as those back home. I'm not sure his judgment can be trusted."

"I am glad to hear your health is improving," said Garen. He glanced sideward, where the warden was leaning over to speak in a low voice to the Lord of the Nockmirch. Both of them seemed distracted for the moment.

"Though tell me, great-uncle," said Garen, "why did you not write that Lord Eldwyn had lost his wife? Or of the construction of the bridge?"

"I'm sorry, my boy, I am behind on my communications," said Hargold. "My illness. But all is well, I assure you."

"What is your take on the lord castellan?" said Garen, lowering his voice to a whisper. "He seems belligerent. Could he be planning to attack his neighbors in Rijenland?"

"No, no, no," said Hargold. "He's not been the same since the death of his wife, but he's not a fool. And in the warden he has a good military advisor. He's a just man, solid and dependable. Now, let me tell you about the unseemly weather we've been having…"

Garen sat back, frowning.

None of this sat right with him. He'd been sent here to check on the ambassador, and assess the situation. Something here made him uneasy.

Despite what Hargold said, it boded ill that the Nockmirch was fortifying its western border. And that bridge…

From a strategic point of view, that bridge would allow the Nockmirch to march its strength into Rijenland whenever it chose, with little warning. The Nockmirch didn't have an army that could ever threaten Demacia, but it could quite easily take Rijenland, should it choose to forsake peace.

Garen rubbed his eyes.

To his tutors' eternal frustration, young Garen had never had an interest in history, not like his sister. Truth be told, he had been a poor student in most areas, bored easily and always longing to escape the confines of the study rooms to practice his swordplay. The only histories he had enjoyed were those detailing the famous deeds and battles of Demacian heroes, dealing with the logistics of war, the numbers of soldiers present, and the movement of troops—most of the texts he'd been assigned focused more on politics, bureaucracy, and economics, and only rarely touched on the battles themselves. Boring.

Still, some of the monotonous teachings he'd been forced to endure had stuck with him into adulthood. He remembered learning how, in the centuries after the Founding, Demacia worked hard to forge treaties and alliances between the independent nations to its east, and how sometimes, as a last resort, it had even enforced peace with the sword. That accord reached only as far as the Nockmirch, however; the lands further east were regarded as much more barbaric and warlike.

Garen knew it suited Demacia to have an array of independent nations on its border. Were one nation to conquer those different lands, then they could become a threat, and so it was in the interest of the crown to ensure each nation's independence. The alliances had also proven mutually beneficial

for all the nations involved, bringing increased prosperity and security to the whole region, or at least so Garen recalled from his teachings.

Could the situation here in the Nockmirch upset the balance? It seemed absurd to Garen that Alderburg would even consider breaking its treaties to attack a neighbouring land, for the consequences would be swift and harsh. Demacia would respond instantly to any call for aid, and send forth its battalions.

Garen shook his head. It made no sense, and he had little patience for these games.

"You need to be able to navigate the intrigues of court politics if you ever wish to become High Marshal," Tianna had told him, once. In truth, there was nothing he desired less.

Garen had never aspired to a position of leadership. Indeed, while he was deeply proud to lead the Dauntless Vanguard, and determined to lead it well, there were more days than not when he longed for the simplicity of being a soldier in the line once more.

"…of course, but the air is very fresh out here, we've not seen any raiders for many months, almost a year," the ambassador was saying. Garen had completely lost track of the conversation, but grunted and nodded his head as the older man wittered on.

Garen sat up suddenly. Across the crowded great hall, a side door had been pushed open, and a figure hurried through.

"Quinn," he breathed.

****

The great hall was loud, and all but the closest revelers were oblivious to Quinn's sudden arrival.

The hall guard tried to stop Quinn, but she avoided his grasp deftly and swept past him. Garen noted that she had her crossbow slung at her side. Garen tensed, ready for whatever was to come.

Another guard made to intercept her as she angled toward the high table, but she ducked into the center of the hall, putting tables between them. More guards noticed, and began pushing through the crowd, knocking servants roughly aside in their haste to stop Quinn. Still the feast continued, oblivious.

Seeing Merrek turn to look up at him, Garen inclined his head toward Quinn. At a word from the sergeant, the Vanguard rose to their feet. One of the guards finally stepped in front of Quinn, blocking her progress, but the massive figure of Kriel was suddenly there, placing a giant hand upon the soldier's chest.

"No," the Stonehorn rumbled, audible to Garen even over the hall's hubbub.

The music stopped, and most of the nobles and servants were looking around in concern now, the feast finally forgotten. Garen was on his feet at the high table, as was the warden. The Lord of the Nockmirch glared across the hall at Quinn, while old Hargold continued to speak, seemingly unaware of it all.

"Get out of my way," snarled the guard, trying to push past Kriel, but he may as well have been trying to barge a mountain aside.

"What's happening?" wailed one of the children still clustered around Kriel.

"Run along, little ones," he growled, not taking his eyes off the guard, and the children scampered away, to the safety of parents and older siblings.

Quinn reached the steps leading up to the high table, but guards barred

her progress. Others closed in, pushing servants and revelers out of the way to surround her.

The Dauntless Vanguard closed ranks around Quinn. Such was their reputation that even though the Demacians were unarmed, the fear in the eyes of the guards facing them was obvious.

“Have you no respect!” barked the Lord of the Nockmirch from his seat. He swung toward Garen, fury burning in his eyes. “You dare bring weapons to my hearth?”

Garen ignored him, looking past the guards to the ranger-knight. “Quinn?” he said.

“*Noxians*,” she hissed.

Garen’s brow darkened, and his jaw clenched.

“Vanguard,” he ordered. “We are leaving. Great-uncle, I would advise you to come with us.”

“Leaving?” said the ambassador, grabbing hold of Garen’s arm. His grip was stronger than expected. “No, no, no, you can’t leave, dear boy. Whatever this is, I’m sure it is just a misunderstanding.”

Garen turned toward the old man, eyes narrowing. There was a strange light in Hargold’s eyes.

“Tell me, *great-uncle*,” Garen said. “What is our family motto?”

“What? What are you speaking of boy! This is not the time for games!”

“I agree,” said Garen. His expression hardened. “And I say again, what is our family motto?”

“This is absurd! You will damage our nation’s relationship with—”

“It’s not a difficult question,” interrupted Garen.

“This is hardly the time—”

There were gasps as Garen grabbed the ambassador by the front of his

shift, pulling him in close, so their faces were only inches apart.

“What are you… Unhand me, boy!” snapped Hargold, struggling to break Garen’s grip. The ambassador was *far* stronger than he looked, but Garen’s grip was like iron.

“Tell me, and I’ll release you,” he hissed.

“I… I don’t…” stammered the ambassador.

“Strength through discipline; honor through diligence,” said Garen. “Every Crownguard learns that before they can walk, as you would know if you were of the family. Who are you?”

“Let the old man go, captain,” growled Warden Vigrid. “You are acting irrational.”

Garen ignored him. “Who *are* you?” he repeated.

The ambassador smiled at Garen, his kind demeanour dropping away to reveal something malignant and dangerous. His smile turned sly and cruel, and his eyes flashed for the briefest of moments, like those of a night-predator catching firelight, only these ones shone with a bright, magenta light.

He’d seen more magic in the last year than he’d care to see in a lifetime.

Garen spun the ambassador—or whatever he was—around, and wrenched one arm up behind his back in a forceful lock, making him wince.

Guards warily approached Garen, halberds leveled.

He looked over at the Lord of the Nockmirch.

“Enemies have infiltrated the Nockmirch, Lord Eldwyn,” declared Garen. “This is not who you think it is.”

The lord castellan scowled.

“No one has infiltrated the Nockmirch,” he declared. “I *invited* them in.”

Warden Vigrid placed one big hand on Lord Eldwyn’s shoulder, and

smiled at Garen, all hint of comradeship discarded. Only now did he realize who was really in control here…

“You have no honor,” Garen breathed.

The Lord of the Nockmirch met his stare. “I had no choice,” he said.

“There is *always* a choice,” snapped Garen.

“Enemies have been on our doorstep for years, and Demacia didn’t want to know. Honor doesn’t matter when your lands are burning and your people are dying. I did what I had to do.”

Garen glared at him, still holding the ambassador in a tight armlock. “Demacia protects its allies.”

“You speak of choice, but you could not even protect poor Jarvan, your own king. And you call yourself a *Crownguard*,” the Lord of the Nockmirch snarled, making Garen flinch. “You say you are the shield of Demacia, but that is a lie. *We* are the shield of Demacia! We are the ones out here on the fringes, an alliance of pawns to keep your enemies at arm’s length. And while you remain safe behind your white walls, we are the ones bleeding to keep your precious Demacia safe! No more. My duty is to *my* people. I chose, and I made the only choice that would see them safe.”

“We are leaving this hall, and I am taking this *deceiver* with us,” Garen commanded, shouldering past the guards and down into the hall. “Any attempt to stop us will go badly for you.”

“The only act of hostility here has been at your hands, Demacian,” said the warden. His accent was stronger now, and Garen realized he wasn’t from the Nockmirch at all…

“Silence, *Noxian*,” snarled Garen, backing slowly away.

Warhorns sounded. They were coming from outside Alderburg itself, and everyone in the hall looked around in shock. Was the hillfort under attack?

“We need to go, now!” Quinn barked.

“What the…” Garen breathed.

Standing atop the dais, staring directly at him, was the ambassador. But then, who was he holding?

He pushed the figure in his arms to the cobbled floor, his eyes wide in shock. The ambassador got to his feet and turned to face Garen, smiling. It was a perfect duplicate of the one standing on the raised platform.

“Sorcery!” hissed Alys Morn.

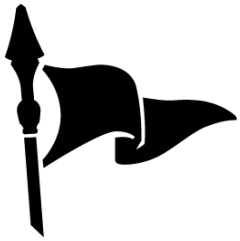
The ambassador Garen had been holding walked purposefully toward Garen, becoming increasingly transparent with every step. By the time he was close, he had all but dissipated, like smoke. Then the apparition was gone completely.

For a moment, it seemed there were two beings standing where the other ambassador stood, up by the high table, one overlapping the other. That second, ghost image now looked very different; a raven-haired woman garbed in darkness, her eyes mocking and her lips curled in a cruel smile. Garen blinked, and she was gone.

Warden Vigrid folded his massive arms across his broad chest.

“Kill them,” he said.

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Chapter Seven

The great hall erupted. Benches crashed to the floor. Plates shattered. Nobles and servants scrambled toward the doors, shouting and screaming, trampling over each other in their haste to get away.

Garen saw hesitation among the guards surrounding the Vanguard. They were likely stunned by the magnitude of what they had just been ordered to do, but that moment of indecision was all he needed.

Stepping forward, he grabbed the haft of the closest guard's halberd in one armored hand. The soldier resisted, and Garen yanked him forward, straight into a vicious elbow strike that slammed into the side of his head, wrenching his helmet out of shape with a sickening crunch. The man collapsed to the floor, leaving Garen holding his weapon.

"Vanguard!" Garen bellowed. "Form up!"

Another soldier lunged at him, but Garen slammed the thrust aside and kicked the man away, sending him sprawling into a nearby table. A third soldier attacked, but Garen simply swayed aside from the clumsy swing, and struck him hard across the head with the butt of his halberd in return, breaking the man's jaw.

Alys Morn stepped in close to one guard, pushing aside a thrust of his halberd with the flat of one hand. In the same movement, she punched up into his throat, putting all her armored weight into the blow. She twisted the halberd from his grasp as he fell, gasping for air.

The other guards surrounding the Vanguard attacked, finally jolted into action. Several stepped forward, thrusting the spiked tips of their halberds at the Demacians. One, more eager than the others, bellowed and brought the

axe-head of his halberd down toward Shield-Sergeant Merrek. It would have caved in his head had it landed… but it didn't.

Kriel caught the haft of that halberd on its way down, and one deft twist sent the Nockmirch soldier flying. "Yours," he said, tossing the weapon to his sergeant.

"Thank you," said Merrek.

Garen smashed another soldier to the ground, and cast his gaze about the room, seeking the sorcerer who had been impersonating his great-uncle. There was no sign of the mage, and he cursed under his breath.

He felt movement behind him, and spun to face a lunging guard. A bolt took the man in the neck, and he dropped silently. Garen nodded his thanks to Quinn, who fell in at his side.

"Do you have eyes on the sorcerer?" he asked.

"No," said Quinn. She scanned the crowd. "It could be anyone."

Garen cursed again.

"It's getting harder and harder to tell friend from foe," he growled. "When did everything become so complicated?"

Quinn shot him a glance. "Friend and foe, right and wrong," she said. "Believe what you will, but it's never been as simple as that."

Garen was about to respond when side doors into the hall were thrown open, and soldiers bearing crossbows ran though.

"'Ware the flank!" he bellowed.

Quinn leapt up onto one of the banquet tables to get a clearer shot. Two enemies dropped a second later, each with a bolt embedded in their throats, but others were hastily readying their heavy weapons.

"Take them! Protect your castellan!" roared the warden, gesturing at the cluster of Demacians, even as he ushered the old Lord of the Nockmirch

toward a back door.

Unlike Quinn's finely wrought weapon, which was light and fired from a magazine, the Nockmirch weapons were heavy and slow, but they made up for it in sheer power.

There was a flurry of twangs as the first of the deadly weapons fired. A thick bolt struck the table next to Garen, embedding itself deeply in the hardwood, while another, missing its intended target, took a fleeing reveler in the back, punching him from his feet.

A Vanguard from Rosk's Eighth Shield was struck, the thick bolt hitting him square in the chest. The force of the blow knocked him back half a step, denting but not penetrating his brightsteel breastplate.

Quinn was not nearly as heavily protected as the others, however. Her ranger's armor was made for speed and ease of movement, not raw stopping power. She was far more vulnerable, but speed was her ally.

Darting along the tabletops, Quinn killed two more crossbowmen with bolts of her own, but additional guards were pushing through the last of the guests desperately trying to escape.

Another side door was thrown open, and a handful more crowded through. Kriel bellowed and upended a massive wooden table, flipping it end over end in their direction. Plates, goblets, and platters of food were hurled in every direction, and the table bowled into the newcomers, crushing several and sending the others scattering.

A little boy, no more than four summers old, was revealed beneath the table, tears running down his face. Garen saw Kriel scoop the child up in one giant hand, tucking him under his arm.

"On me, Vanguard!" roared Garen. The Demacians formed up around him, creating a tight knot of steel. Most were armed, now. "Battle pace.

Forward!”

“Seal the doors!” came a shout, but now the Vanguard had momentum behind them, nothing was going to stop them.

They drove clear of the great hall, slamming the heavy wooden doors wide before they could be barred, crushing all who stood in their path.

Kriel handed off the child to a panicked serving woman. “See him safe,” he ordered.

The terrified woman nodded, and ran into the darkness.

Revelers and servants scattered from the keep, running in every direction. More soldiers were pushing against the flow, heading up the steep hill toward Garen and his honor guard.

Horns blared, closer now.

And in the distance, torches burned. Hundreds and hundreds of them, heading for Alderburg.

****

“Scales.”

Eben Hess’ confident grin dropped as the Nockmirch soldier sitting across the table from him turned over the heavy playing disk, revealing the scales symbol carved into its underside. The other Nockmirchers crowded around the dingy, lamp-lit room—soldiers shirking their duties, mostly—gave a raucous cheer, spilling more than a little ale in their enthusiasm.

They were playing tellstones, and Hess was losing. Badly.

“Looks like I’ll be taking the rest of your money then, Demacian,” said his opponent, grinning to reveal several big gaps in his teeth.

The man was suddenly not looking nearly as drunk as had just moments before, and Hess’ eyes narrowed. Reaching across the table, he grabbed the

Nockmircher’s goblet. The man had been gulping from it liberally for the past hour, and it had been refilled a number of times. Hess took a sniff, and his suspicions were confirmed.

“Water,” he snarled, hurling the cup aside. “You played me.”

His opponent simply smiled back at him, and pointed at another of the tokens arranged before him.

“Swords,” he declared.

Hess cursed under his breath, and eyed the bulging coin purse to the side of the table. More than a full season’s pay was at stake, and he was about to lose it all.

A horn sounded in the distance.

Everyone in the room went still, listening, all sounds of chatter and laughter ceasing. A second horn blared, and the room snapped into motion.

Hess took advantage of the moment of confusion, snatching the coin purse and making a break for the door, knocking his stool over in his haste. His opponent grabbed at him, but Hess punched him square in the face, and he fell back, blood splattering from his broken nose.

He burst out of the small hovel, hearing the horns clearer now. People were running from the keep above, their screams carrying down to him faintly on the evening breeze. Soldiers were marching toward it, weapons drawn.

A heavy hand slapped down on his shoulder.

“Think you better stay with us, Demacian,” said one of the men who had been laughing and drinking at the dice table a moment earlier. He was a big bastard, and had a short sword drawn.

Hess grabbed the man’s wrist and twisted it sharply, making him double over with a whine, before slamming his fist down onto the now straightened

elbow. The joint shattered with a wet crunch.

Then Hess was moving, running hard through the settlement, tucking his ill-gotten winnings down inside his breastplate.

Horns sounded again, closer.

People of the Nockmirch milled around in confusion, emerging from their homes clutching children, eyes wide in fear. Clearly, they believed themselves under attack.

A detachment of crossbowmen were trooping from the main gatehouse in the palisade toward the barracks where his comrades were billeted.

They were moving *away* from the gates—and those heavy wooden gates were being swung wide open, rather than pulled shut and fortified.

Hess' gut clenched up. This wasn't a raid. This was something else.

He increased his pace, sprinting across the muddy roadway toward the barracks.

"Vanguard!" he bellowed, as he got closer. "To arms!"

He stormed into the barracks, breathing hard. Reika Kol of Fourth was already fully garbed for war while, behind her, the other Vanguard were slipping arms through shield straps and readying blades.

"Report, soldier!" the shield-sergeant barked.

"Trouble at the keep," he said. He caught his helmet, tossed to him by the new recruit, Cithria, and slipped it on. It fit snugly, like a second skin. "And enemy incoming, from outside the walls."

"An enemy is attacking Alderburg?" asked Kol, brow furrowing.

"No," said Hess, securing his shield to his arm. "The Nockmirch is opening the gates to them. They come for *us*."

****

“Looks like things—” said Saskja Vos.

“—are about to get interesting,” finished her twin, Rurik, giving Cithria a wink.

“Let’s move, Vanguard!” bellowed Sergeant Kol. “Our sword-captain needs us!”

A detachment of Nockmirch soldiers was waiting for them as they burst from the barracks. The defenders of Eighth took the lead, their massive brightsteel shields held before them. A flurry of crossbow bolts met them as soon as they stepped from the barracks, but they clattered harmlessly against their shields, leaving barely a dent.

As soon as Eighth were out, they formed a wall, interlocking their shields. The soldiers of First and Fourth Shield hurried out to join them, forming the second and third rank. Then they advanced.

The crossbowmen dropped back to reload, allowing others to step forward, leveling their own weapons.

This second wave of bolts proved as ineffective as the first, doing nothing to stop the Vanguard’s inexorable advance, and the crossbowmen who had loosed them faltered, shock clear on their faces.

A third volley broke against the Demacians. The enemy were only twenty paces away now.

“Break!” shouted Kol.

Instantly, the Vanguard of Eighth Shield split, half stepping left, half stepping right. The soldiers of First and Fourth surged through the gap.

A volley of bolts enveloped the charging Demacians, but it had been fired in haste, and most missed their mark or clanged off shield and armor. Then the gap was closed, and the Demacians slammed into the Nockmirch line.

Crossbows fell to the mud as the Nockmirchers drew short blades, but

they were hopelessly outclassed.

A sword flashed toward Cithria, and she parried and thrust in one practiced motion, her blade taking her opponent in the chest. There were cries of pain and fear, and then it was over.

The remaining enemy soldiers fled, desperate to escape the avenging Demacians, their will to stand and fight shattered.

Cithria looked down at the soldier she had run through. He clutched at the wound in his chest as his lifeblood leaked onto the ground. He looked up at her, eyes full of fear.

It was the boy from the barracks, the one who'd dropped the mead.

"I'm cold," he said in a soft voice. Then the life left him, and he went limp.

Breathing heavily, Cithria stared down at him, while blood dripped from the tip of her sword.

"Snap out of it, soldier!"

Startled from her reverie, Cithria looked up to see Shield-Sergeant Kol standing before her.

Cithria nodded, and tightened her grip on her sword. Her Shield needed her.

"I'm fine, shield-sergeant," she said.

"Good to hear it," said Kol, then raised her voice. "Vanguard, on me!"

The Demacians formed up. They all had additional wargear slung over their shoulders—the weapons and shields of their comrades up at the keep. Kol had Garen's famed broadsword hung across her back, bearing its weight stoically.

"Let's move," the shield-sergeant ordered.

****

Garen and his honor guard were advancing slowly down the hill, beneath the shadow of the keep. Nockmirch soldiers attacked from the front and the rear, but their efforts were disjointed and disorganized. He needed to get his force away before an officer organized this rabble, for the Demacians were heavily outnumbered. But for now, bedlam and confusion were their allies.

Quinn snapped off a shot from her crossbow, taking a charging enemy in the chest. He dropped as if his legs had been cut from under him.

“Garen!” she shouted, pointing down the hill.

The sword-captain saw a knot of silver-armored figures advancing steadily toward them. *Vanguard*.

“Break through, and regroup!” he shouted, gesturing to their comrades.

“Stay tight!” bellowed Merrek, and the honor guard advanced as one.

Alys Morn impaled an enemy soldier on the spike of her halberd as she ran, and Kriel sent another flying with a backhanded fist. Merrek cut another down, hacking him out of the way with a sword he’d torn from the grasp of a fallen soldier.

Garen shifted the grip on his borrowed halberd, hefting it like a javelin. He took a few more steps, then hurled it with a grunt of effort. It took a charging Nockmirch soldier in the chest, lifting him from his feet.

The knot of Demacians advancing from below opened up their formation as Garen reached it.

“Castle up!” shouted Reika Kol. “Good to see the bastards didn’t get you, captain.”

With perfect discipline, the Vanguard closed around Garen and his honor guard, facing outward, while they ditched the inferior enemy weapons in

favor of their own.

“Thank you, shield-sergeant,” Garen said as Kol shrugged Judgment off her shoulders. He drew the massive sword, and the blade gleamed in the moonlight, the tiny, swirling patterns created during its forging rippling along its surface.

Garen glanced over at Quinn. The ranger-knight was kneeling nearby, taking advantage of the Vanguard’s protective formation to reload the magazine of her repeater crossbow.

“Any chance of us getting out the east gates before the enemy arrive?” he said.

Quinn shook her head. “The Noxian warhost is close. We go out there, we’ll be surrounded. Even if we somehow got past them, we’d be harried for a hundred miles before we could cross the Silverrun to the west.”

“Could we hole up in the keep?” said Merrek. “Or take one of the gatehouses?”

Garen frowned. Holding a fortification, the Vanguard would certainly exact a punishing toll on the enemy assailing them. But making the decision to hold here was effectively a death sentence.

“We stay, we die,” said Garen. “No, we have to keep moving. Our main priority now is to get word to the capital that Noxus is making a play to advance westward.”

The Nockmirch soldiers began to regain a semblance of order, under barked commands from their superiors. Arrows and bolts ricocheted off Demacian shields, and the first clusters of Nockmirchers attacked the formation, but the four sides of the Vanguard formation held strong.

“We don’t have long,” warned Quinn.

Garen swore under his breath. The range of options open to them were

slim.

“We take the bridge,” he said, finally.

Merrek nodded, slowly.

“That’s the clearest way out of here,” he said. “But if they seal the tower on the other side before we are over, we’ll be in trouble.”

“It’s the best chance we’ve got,” said Garen. “And even if our way is blocked, Quinn can get out. She can carry word back to Demacia.”

“By your word, sword-captain,” snapped Merrek. Kol and Rosk met Garen’s gaze and nodded.

An instant later, Quinn gave a curt nod, though she didn’t look particularly happy about it. “By your word.”

On their sergeants’ orders, the Demacians reformed, in perfect lockstep. The four walls of their castle formation dissolved, and they spread apart in a loose skirmish line. At another order, they ran toward the central crossroad at the heart of the settlement. Garen glanced at Alderburg’s east wall. Its gates were wide open, and a living flood of warriors were streaming through. He could tell at a glance that these were not Nockmirch soldiers. These were far more dangerous.

“At the double!” shouted Garen.

The Vanguard sprinted through the muddy town, toward the heavily fortified gatehouse marking the entrance to the newly constructed bridge. Panicked stragglers scattered in their path, though most townspeople had now barricaded themselves inside their homes, doors and windows slammed shut. The Vanguard swept aside the few Nockmirch troops that tried to stop them, though one of their number—Hollun, of Fourth Shield—sprawled unexpectedly in the mud, as if he’d tripped.

Two of his Shield dragged Hollun back to his feet, but he flopped loosely

in their arms, a crossbow bolt jutting from his left eye socket. He had been dead before he even hit the ground. Garen glanced behind them, toward the distant east gate. The roadway was filled with enemies rushing to close the distance with them.

“Leave him,” Garen growled.

“But—” began Sergeant Kol, but Garen cut her off.

“Tonight, our duty is to the living, not the dead,” Garen barked. “We have to move!”

With considerable reluctance, they left Hollun where he’d fallen, and sprinted through the center of Alderburg in loose formation, slipping and sliding in the mud. The fortified gate leading onto the bridge loomed before them. Shouts echoed from its battlements.

“Shields up!” shouted Garen, and a second later the air was filled with a flurry of bolts, clattering off their shields like stones.

The portcullis was still raised—confusion still reigned—leaving the way onto the bridge clear, but as they pounded up the embankment toward the gateway, it began to drop. The sound of chain unspooling was deafening as it thundered down to block their escape.

“Kriel!” barked Merrek, and the Stonehorn leapt forward. He stormed up the rise, his steel-shod hooves kicking up mud. He dropped his sword, and skidded underneath the falling portcullis. He caught it over his head, abruptly silencing the ratcheting chain.

The weight drove him to one knee, the veins in his thick neck bulging. With a roar, he pushed slowly back to his feet, straightening his arms overhead. His whole body was shuddering beneath the burden, however; he could not hold it for long. With a creaking groan, the iron portcullis began to lower.

Sheathing Judgment, Garen swung in beside Kriel and pushed upward, lending his own strength.

“Move!” ordered Merrek, ushering the Demacians through.

“Just… a moment… longer,” grunted Garen. His arms were beginning to shudder.

“I could… do this… all day,” said Kriel, making Garen snort.

The rest of the Vanguard ducked through.

“That’s everyone!” called Merrek.

Together, Kriel and Garen stepped back, releasing the portcullis. It crashed down with a boom that made the entire bridge shudder.

“The sentries up top?” said Merrek, nodding toward the upper levels of the gatehouse above.

“We have to take them out before we advance,” said Garen. He made to lead the way up the stairs to the next level of the tower, but Merrek held a hand before him.

“We can take care of this, sword-captain,” he said, in a low voice.

Garen said nothing for a moment, then nodded curtly.

“First Shield!” Merrek bellowed. “Clear this tower!”

Hess led the way, leaping eagerly up the stairs, the rest of First Shield—barring Kriel, who couldn’t fit—close behind.

Garen turned to stare down the length of the bridge. Mist swallowed it halfway along, hiding the distant gatehouse on the other side. His instinct was to take it in a sudden charge, but a rare moment of doubt assailed him.

The squat fortifications on each side of the bridge were designed to defend against enemies storming them—from either side. It had seemed a strange design, but now it made more sense to Garen. Noxus had claimed this bridge not for the Nockmirch, but for itself. And once those portcullises

were down, there was no way of bypassing them short of demolishing them with battering rams and siege engines.

“I’ll make sure the way is open,” said Quinn. Garen hadn’t realized she was nearby, watching with those unblinking amber eyes. Was he truly so easy to read?

Garen hesitated.

“You need to break free and go,” he said. “Demacia needs to know what’s happening, before it’s too late. We can handle things here.”

“If you advance in force along the bridge, they’ll bar the way before you get close, and you’ll be trapped,” said Quinn. “The best chance is to take the tower before they realize we’re coming. And we need to do it fast. Only I can do that.”

“Your priority is getting word back to Demacia,” he said. “Everything else is secondary. *Everything*.”

“I know,” said Quinn. “But at least give me the chance to open the way for you and your soldiers.”

Garen didn’t doubt her ability, but still he hesitated.

“Fine,” he said after a moment, coming to a decision. “But we can’t hold here for long. We’ll move across as soon as this tower is secure. And if it looks too risky, just break and run. That’s an order. Getting word out is too important.”

Quinn nodded. “See you on the other side,” she said, with a half smile.

Garen saluted, and then she was off, running lightly across the bridge.

“Protector guide you,” he said, watching as she disappeared into the mist.

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Quinn was swallowed by the fog, so that she could see neither the tower

behind her, nor the one in front. That suited her just fine. If she couldn't see them, they couldn't see her either.

Quinn increased her pace, arms pumping. The gatehouse was designed to stop an army in its tracks, and she was just one ranger, but she had a job to do. The Vanguard were relying on her, and she was their shepherd. To see them safely home, that was her charge, and she would not fail them.

"Valor, to me!" she called as she ran.

He called in response, the sound cutting through the dark. Without hesitation, Quinn leapt up onto the battlements and launched herself over the edge.

For a moment she was dropping like a stone toward the distant falls below. Then Valor was there, and his massive talons latching on to her, and she was no longer falling. Now she was *soaring*.

As broad as Valor's wings were, her weight was too great for true flight. Nevertheless, he was easily capable of gliding while bearing her.

The ravine fell away below her, and Quinn smiled.

"Faster, my friend," she whispered, and Valor eagerly complied. Tucking in his wings, he sent them into a steep dive, making Quinn squint against the cold rush.

They swooped down, passing underneath the bridge, then used their momentum to rise into a climbing arc, the cool, misty air billowing up from the falls aiding their ascent.

They were now higher than the gatehouse itself. Braziers burned atop the tower, the coiling flames lighting the handful of soldiers posted to watch the Rijenland approach. There were five in all, staring into the mist, trying to make sense of the muffled sounds coming from within Alderburg. They had no idea what was going on.

Banking sharply, Valor turned into a dive toward the tower.

“Now!” Quinn barked.

Valor released his grip, and the ranger-knight dropped fifteen feet, landing in a roll on the tower. Valor continued his dive, grabbing one of the Nockmirch soldiers by his leather cap, talons digging deep, and dragged him over the edge, dropping him into the ravine. His screams echoed through the night, and as the others turned in shock, Quinn jumped to her feet, killing two of them with quick shots from her crossbow.

The remaining two foes spun, shock written on their faces. One shakily fired his crossbow, the bolt narrowly missing Quinn. The other raised his weapon to his shoulder, but was distracted by a flap of wings as Valor came back around for another pass.

Cursing, the soldier turned, aiming skyward.

“No!” screamed Quinn, leaping forward, even as the soldier pulled the release.

The bolt shot up at Valor, and he fell out of sight with a keening cry and flutter of feathers.

Hot rage boiled up within Quinn, and she slammed the butt of her crossbow into the side of the soldier’s head. He staggered, dropping his weapon, and clutched the side of the parapet for balance. Before he could recover, Quinn drew her large hunting knife and plunged it into his neck. He gaped up at her, and toppled over the edge, falling down into the chasm below.

The last soldier was hurriedly slotting a new bolt into place on his crossbow. Quinn turned and hurled her knife in one smooth action. The blade spun end over end and thudded into the soldier’s chest, embedding itself to the hilt. He looked down at it, his expression one of incredulity,

then slid to the ground.

“Valor!” Quinn cried, leaning over the battlements, looking down. She saw nothing but a single, deep blue feather, bobbing left and right as it fell toward the roaring river below.

Grief clutched at her, and Quinn fell to her knees. Movement at the corner of her vision made her look up. Garen and the other Vanguard were appearing out of the mist, having cleared the other guard tower, and were hurrying across the bridge.

Duty forced her back to her feet. Barely focusing, she stumbled down the tight, spiraling stairs from the top of the gatehouse. One floor below, she came to the mechanism controlling the portcullis. Heavy chains hitched over a series of massive pulleys overhead, before wrapping around a large, geared winch. Those chains were attached to immense counterweights, such that even a single soldier was easily able to raise the portcullis below.

Quinn hauled the handles of the winch, sending the counterweights downward, and the portcullis below began to move, chains and cogs clunking. Pulling hard, she had it raised in moments, before slotting the locking mechanism in place.

A keening cry sounded from above.

“Valor!” Quinn cried out, racing back up the tightly spiraling stairs to the roof.

The azurite eagle was there, standing crookedly atop the battlements, wings spread, and Quinn raced over to him.

“I thought I’d lost you, my brother!” she said, relief washing over her like a fresh spring.

He was favoring one leg, and there was blood on his feathers. He tried to put weight on his injured leg but faltered, letting out a pained cry, and

flapping his wings to keep from overbalancing.

Quinn leapt up onto the raised step directly behind the crenellations, to put herself on the same level as the proud bird of prey. She reached out to him, and he nuzzled into her hand, pressing his head against her, and trilling softly.

“You’ll be okay,” she said. “We’ll get you fixed up, old friend.”

She looked down, seeing Garen and the Vanguard approaching the now open gateway below. Garen hefted his sword high in salute, and Quinn lifted her hand in acknowledgement.

Valor’s head snapped around suddenly, and he gave a deafening cry, eyes locking on to something behind Quinn.

Whipping around, she saw the last guard, the one with her knife still embedded in his chest. Her blow had been fatal… but for the moment, he was still alive, and his crossbow was leveled at her.

There was a sharp snap, and the wind was driven out of her. It felt like she’d been kicked in the chest by a horse.

“Damn,” she breathed, staring down at the bolt jutting from her chest.

She wobbled for a moment, then collapsed. Through the pain, she saw the dying soldier limply drop his crossbow, and stagger down the spiraling stairs. Quinn tried to pull herself across the stone after him, knowing what he was about to do, but she was fading fast. She slumped over onto her back, out of strength, and found herself staring up at the sky.

In a flutter of wings, Valor landed awkwardly beside her, wings outspread and favoring one leg. He uttered a soft coo of concern.

Quinn knew she didn’t have long. Struggling to stay conscious, she wrapped one gloved hand around the thick crossbow bolt embedded in her ribcage, and yanked it free in one sudden motion. She grimaced as she did

it, but did not cry out. Blood pooled beneath her.

“Valor…” she breathed, weakly. Her arm flopped to the ground, and the bloody crossbow bolt rolled from her grasp before the eagle’s talons.

Valor let loose a keening, mournful cry.

****

Garen saw the dark silhouette of Valor take to the air above. Was there something clutched in the eagle’s claws? The huge bird circled the tower once, emitting another lonesome cry, then struck out due west.

A moment later, Garen watched in horror as the portcullis ahead dropped with an echoing rattle. There was no one to catch this one, and it slammed down with a thunderous crash that made the bridge shudder.

The way was blocked.

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Chapter Eight

Whoever designed this bridge knew their business," said Merrek, shaking his head. "There are no damn handholds in the stone, and no mortar to be carved away. Without ladders or ropes, we're not getting past this tower."

Garen nodded. He could appreciate the brutal cunning of the bridge's design. It was clear to him now that this was Noxian war-masonry. He'd been a fool not to have recognized it before.

Nearby, Kriel and a handful of other soldiers strained to lift the portcullis, but it didn't budge an inch. With a puff of frustration, the Stonehorn gave up.

"It's no good," he boomed. "The mechanism is locked. We'd need a battering ram to get through."

"Looks like we stand and fight," said Garen.

"Did Quinn get away, do you think?" asked Merrek, leaning in close to him.

Garen nodded. "I saw her eagle flying west. They made it across. She can't man the ship alone, so she'll be making her way overland as we speak."

"Moves fast, that one."

"She does," said Garen. "And she's resourceful, and knows the land. She'll probably get back quicker than we could row."

"I thought she'd done it, too," said Merrek, looking up at the tower blocking their way.

"I ordered her to get word back to the capital at all cost," said Garen. "If

she ran into trouble, she made the wise decision to cut and run."

Garen turned to look back toward Alderburg. The mists had parted, and in the torchlight he could see hundreds of soldiers pushing onto the bridge.

"Now, our role is to hold long enough to buy her time to get clear of pursuit," he said.

His expression hardened, and he drew Judgment, its silver blade ringing as he slid it from its scabbard.

"Come, Vanguard!" he called. "We are the shield of Demacia. Let's show them what that means."

****

Cithria tried to slow her rapid heartbeat, taking in deep breaths.

The Dauntless Vanguard stood in the center of the bridge, in three tight ranks.

Eighth Shield were in front, their massive brightsteel shields overlapping to form an impenetrable wall. First Shield were ranked up tightly behind, and Fourth Shield formed a reserve.

All of them knew what their role was: to hold here and buy Quinn the time to get to safety, and carry word of treachery back home.

Thankfully, the bridge forced the enemy to come at them on a narrow front, where their greater numbers could not be brought to bear. The enemy would have a hard time dislodging them… but there were an awful lot of them.

Cithria could see the warden atop the bridge tower on the Nockmirch side, orchestrating the approaching army. And it was an army; her best guess was there were almost two thousand enemy warriors here, on top of perhaps two hundred soldiers and guards of the Nockmirch. The warden

had taken direct command of both hosts, with the lord castellan nowhere to be seen.

To her Demacian eyes, they were an unruly rabble, these newcomers, with no sense of uniformity in their ranks. They all seemed to be armed differently from each other, apparently at the whim of each warrior, and they wore a broad range of armor, from incredibly heavy-looking iron plate to little more than furs and warpaint. The variety in their appearance was staggering. It appeared these warriors—for they were *warriors*, not *soldiers*—had been gathered from far and wide, perhaps from every corner of Valoran, or even beyond.

They marched under a single banner, however. That banner was raised above the tower where the warden stood, alongside those of the Nockmirch. As it rippled in the wind, illuminated by flickering torchlight, Cithria saw a stylized black helmet or skull on a blood-red field, its angles sharp.

“What flag is that?” she said.

“Noxus,” spat Eben Hess, at her side. “These are bloody bastard Noxians.”

“*Noxus*,” breathed Cithria, in wonder. Of course she’d heard stories of the vast barbarian empire of Noxus, far to the east, but it had been many years since there’d been any direct conflict. “Why are they here?”

“Why do you think?” snapped Hess. “The only time Noxus’ll stop waging war on its neighbours is when everyone bends the knee to ’em.” The scowling soldier cleared his throat, and spat on the ground. “Bloody bastard Noxians.”

Two thousand undisciplined warriors were no real threat to her homeland… but how many more of them were there, swarming the lands between the eastern reaches and Demacia? This could just be an advance

force, sent to forge the way ahead. The newly constructed bridge would allow an army ten times this size to march across into Rijenland and take it before Demacia even realized there was a threat. If it moved fast, a hostile army could be at the gates of Demacia in weeks. At the realization, Cithria understood the importance of what they were doing here.

There was movement among the mass of enemy soldiers.

It would not be long, now.

Garen was standing out front, defiant and heroic. He glared at the enemy for a moment longer, then turned away from them, and marched back to the Vanguard lines. He scanned their ranks, and nodded to Cithria. She stood a little taller at his acknowledgment.

The Vanguard stood in perfect order, shields locked together, armor gleaming, and blue cloaks hanging from their shoulders. Cithria felt their determination, strength, and pride. Not one among them gave any indication of fear or apprehension.

“Sons and daughters of Demacia!” Garen shouted. “We are the argent shield! We are the unbreakable wall! Let them break upon us like the waves against the cliffs of Havenfall! They will smash upon our shields and fall before our blades!”

Cithria followed him with her gaze, her eyes mirroring the determination and pride in his own.

“Demacia!” Garen bellowed, thrusting Judgment into the air. The Vanguard echoed his cry, roaring to the heavens, blades raised.

“Demacia!”

****

The soldiers of the Nockmirch were the first to come against them. No

doubt they'd been chosen by the warden as expendable, to be used to test the Demacians' strength. Cithria could feel their apprehension as they marched through the tower gate and began to approach the Vanguard waiting at the center of the bridge.

Forty crossbowmen advanced in tight ranks. Closer and closer they came, until they drew to a halt, some thirty paces from the Demacian line.

The brightsteel wall of Eighth Shield stood resolute in front, shoulder to shoulder. First Shield held their own shields high in the second rank, forming an overlapping layer over their heads.

"Steady," boomed Shield-Sergeant Rosk.

Garen stood among First Shield, at their center. The sword-captain had no shield, but he was protected by those of the other Vanguard around him.

The warden atop the gatehouse shouted a command, and the enemy unleashed their first volley. Bolts flashed across the open space dividing the enemy forces, punching against the shield wall. The first rank of the Nochmirchers stepped back, allowing the second rank to fire as they reloaded, and a second wave of bolts ricocheted off the brightsteel shields. The third rank and the fourth followed suit, but not a single bolt managed to bypass the bulwark.

Realizing that to continue the barrage was pointless, the warden barked an order for them to stop. They turned and slipped back through the ranks behind them. At an order from Merrek, the second rank of the Vanguard lowered their shields. The remainder of the Nockmirch force began to edge forward, wooden shields jostling together and spears held high.

To Cithria, they seemed poorly trained and ill-disciplined. Their advance was stuttering and uneven, betraying the soldiers' hesitation to close the distance with the Vanguard ahead of them. That was understandable. The

Nockmirch soldiers may have outnumbered the Vanguard, but those in the front ranks must have known they marched to their deaths.

Cithria shook her head in regret. She had no desire to fight these soldiers. They were meant to be allies! And she knew this turn of events was not of their doing. The blame for this lay at the feet of their lord, but it would be these soldiers who bled for it.

At twenty paces, the enemy lowered their spears, preparing for the assault.

Cithria saw fear in their eyes.

The Vanguard would take no satisfaction in their defeat. But nor would they show mercy.

One spearman in the front rank let out a wordless shout, which was quickly mirrored by those around him, and the Nockmirch host broke into a charge.

“Now!” roared Garen, and as one the Demacians surged forward to meet the enemy head on.

Their sudden charge took the Nockmirch soldiers by surprise, shocked at the speed and ferocity of the Demacians suddenly bearing down on them.

“Eight Shield, drive!” roared Rosk.

The front rank presented a rapidly advancing wall of steel, with the soldiers of First and Fourth adding their weight to the charge. Not a single spear penetrated that wall, and the Vanguard slammed into the men of the Nockmirch with crushing force.

The press of bodies was heavy and claustrophobic around Cithria, and screams and shouts rang out as the first Nockmirchers died. Dozens fell, trampled underfoot. Stabbing spears pounded against the shields of the Vanguard, but found no weak point. The Demacians pushed forward,

stomping over the fallen and leaving the dead in their wake. A dying Nockmircher grabbed at Cithria's leg, and she put him out of his misery with a thrust to his throat.

The Demacians' grinding, devastating advance began to slow, the sheer press of bodies stalling their progress.

"Repel, and hold!" shouted Garen, and the Vanguard heaved forward as one and halted their advance, shoving the enemy back a step, opening some distance between the two sides. "Now strike true!"

Before the Nockmirch soldiers could recover, the Vanguard stepped forward, closing the gap once more. The front rank opened up their shields, stabbing with their short blades, before slamming them shut once more, presenting yet another impenetrable wall.

"Repel! Strike!" Garen roared, and they performed the maneuver again, slamming the enemy back with the shields, then stepping in and stabbing. Cithria and the other members of First Shield pushed forward behind the Vanguard of Eighth, lending their weight to each shove.

There were lots of them, but the Nockmirchers were being butchered, and Cithria felt their resolve begin to falter.

"First Shield, speartip!" barked Garen, clearly also sensing the enemy's weakness.

Eighth's shieldwall parted instantly, and the sword-captain darted forward swiftly, Judgment clasped tightly in both hands. Cithria roared wordlessly and went with him, along with the other members of First Shield, forming a wedge with Garen at its tip.

"Demacia!" Garen thundered, swinging his blade in a lethal arc. His first blow smashed three spears aside, and his second splintered shields and arms alike. Then he was among them, striking left and right, cutting them down

with impunity.

First Shield was half a step behind, and they crashed into the enemy like a bow wave, blades flashing. Cithria struck hard, driving one soldier to his knees, allowing Eben Hess to stab the soldier inside the gorget. Kriel sent two flying with his shield, and cut down another with a heavy, overhead strike that almost hacked the man in half.

Screams of pain and fear rang out, and the enemy's will to fight shattered. Cithria had seen it before. Panic was infectious, like rot befalling a tree; once it took hold, a single blow could shatter an entire army.

The Nockmirch soldiers turned and fled in one blind, panicked mob back along the bridge, jostling into each other in their haste to escape.

The Vanguard did not pursue them. They were soldiers, not butchers.

The dead and dying were strewn across the bridge, like a foul, bloodied blanket. Cithria looked along the Vanguard ranks. Their armor was unblemished; the Nockmirch blood slid from the silver plates like water off an oilskin, leaving them unmarked. Their blue cloaks were another matter, however, and many now bore dark stains upon them.

No Demacian had fallen, but there were no cheers from the Vanguard. They knew this was not a victory.

This was just the beginning.

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Chapter Nine

If the first assault was sent to test the Demacian line, the second was to sunder it.

Garen stared balefully at the charging enemy. He felt no fear, and no doubts plagued him.

Let them come.

“Honor and glory!” he shouted, raising Judgment high for all to see.

They came in a roaring, screaming tide. These warriors seemed more beast than man, clad in furs and mail, their flesh bedecked in red warpaint and mud. Their hair was long and braided, and their knotted beards festooned with brass and bone. A number ran along the battlements on the sides of the bridge, leaping along the crenellations.

They had no fear of death. Indeed, they welcomed it. *Craved* it.

They leapt upon the Vanguard, howling like wolves, yet for all their savagery, there was a brutal method to their madness.

They hefted war-axes of heavy design, surging forward to hack at the Vanguard. Several heavy blows struck the top of the Eighth’s kite shields, shearing great gouges in the brightsteel. The force of those blows dragged shields down, exposing the Demacians behind. Behind the axemen were warriors armed with short blades, and they swarmed forward to take advantage of the work the axes had done.

The first of the Vanguard to fall on the bridge was a soldier called Theodral, one of Eighth. As he fought to wrench his shield free of the axe embedded in its rim, a wild-haired barbarian lunged, roaring incoherently, and stabbed a blade into his face.

Garen bellowed in fury and slew the man half a second later, Judgment flashing, but it was too late for Theodral, who dropped without a sound.

Eben Hess pushed into the gap, killing two enemies as they advanced, taking advantage of the brief hole in the lines.

The enemy hurled themselves without fear against the shieldwall… but the Demacians held.

“Front rank, back!” Garen bellowed. With practiced synchronicity, Eighth Shield pushed the enemy away, then made a half turn to allow the second two ranks of Vanguard past them. Within heartbeats, First Shield presented a unified front rank. Eben Hess gave the enemy no respite, hacking and cutting as Garen and First Shield joined him at the forefront of the line.

Garen fought with Merrek and Alys Morn to either side. Kriel held the right flank, as ever. It was usually the most vulnerable place in a line, with no Vanguard to one’s side to offer protection, but in First Shield, he was their anchor.

Garen called another rotation, sending First Shield to the rear, allowing them a moment to recover, and keep all his soldiers fresh. Garen stayed in the front rank, now joined by the blades and shields of Fourth.

He lost track of time as he fought, and he had no idea how long had passed when two long blasts of a horn urged the painted barbarians to pull back. They were reluctant to retreat, many of them launching one last, savage attack, before slinking back, scowling, leaving their dead where they lay.

Only now that the fighting had ended did Garen realize how tired he was.

Nevertheless, he knew the enemy would come again, all too soon.

And we’ll be ready, Garen swore.

****

Three Vanguard had fallen in the last wave of fighting. Cithria had seen Cadan of Eighth drop with an axe in his neck, which had killed him almost instantly. Leyton of Fourth was brought to his knees by a brutal blow to his chest, and slain as he struggled to regain his feet.

First Shield, too, had suffered its first casualty.

Rurik Vos had taken a sword thrust under the armpit. The blade had slipped through a joint in his plate, punching through his mail. He was alive, but his face was pale. Alys Morn checked the wound, then shook her head. Saskja held her twin's hands, tears streaming down her face.

"Don't cry, sister," Rurik wheezed, smiling faintly as he looked up at her. "I'll see you—"

"—in the light beyond," Saskja finished, completing her twin's sentence for the last time.

Life faded from Rurik's eyes, and he was gone.

Cithria wanted to comfort Saskja, but didn't know what to say. As she stood watching, feeling helpless and paralyzed, Eben Hess squatted beside the grieving soldier, laying a hand on her shoulder.

"He was a good man," Hess said. "Far, far better than me. If I could give my life to bring him back, I would."

Saskja laid her own hand on top of Hess'. "I know," she said.

Cithria stared at Eben Hess in surprise. She *believed* him, and that fact cast him in a very different light.

Almost all of them bore wounds of some degree. Cithria had a cut across her left cheek that she didn't remember receiving, and her armor was dented in a few places, but she was otherwise unhurt.

She looked at the spread of corpses before the Demacian line. The enemy had not come forward to retrieve their dead, and the Vanguard had no inclination to clear them away; if anything, they would be an impediment to the next Noxian assault. Already, evil-eyed crows were beginning their grisly feast. Beyond them, the vast enemy force gathered, lit by torches and braziers.

The Vanguard had more respect for their fallen. They bore them away from the front line and laid them on their shields, with their blue cloaks draped over them. The injured were tended to as best as possible, under Alys Morn's stern direction. Waterskins were through the ranks, and those who could stomach it ate some rations, chewing on tough, salted meats and handfuls of dried fruit and nuts.

For a soldier, waiting for the enemy to attack was the worst time. It was impossible to properly relax, but the inactivity, combined with the chill of the night and the mist rising from the falls below, conspired to make muscles tighten and lock up. The Noxians seemed in no particular hurry to finish things, either. The longer the battle continued, the more it disadvantaged the Demacians, who could not afford to become lax.

Nevertheless, the longer they held out, the more of a head start they bought Quinn.

"They come again," said Merrek, after what seemed like only minutes, and the Vanguard swiftly regained formation.

The fight was only going to get harder.

****

Twice more the fur-clad barbarian warband hurled itself at the Demacians, straining desperately to pierce the line, and twice more the

Vanguard held true.

Saskja Vos fought like a woman possessed, yet she emerged from both attacks with barely a scratch upon her. Others were not so fortunate.

Three more Vanguard fell—Ralland, Mabyn, and Cathal Laurent—and another two were injured seriously enough to be unable to stand in the line. There were only enough of them now to form two ranks, and the three Shields were now intermingled.

Garen himself had almost been brought down. A painted warrior caught his armor on the hooked chains she wielded, yanking him out of the line and onto his knees. Only the timely intervention of Alys Morn had blocked the cut scything at his neck, one that would surely have beheaded him. Cithria had helped him back to his feet, and Garen nodded his thanks even as Alys Morn dispatched another pair of chain-maidens.

Finally, horns sounded and the enemy pulled back. The Demacians slumped in exhaustion, the toll of battle beginning to wear on them.

Garen looked across at the tower on the Nockmirch side. The warden still stood there, unmoving, arms folded across his chest. He imagined he saw frustration and simmering anger at the Demacians' refusal to take a backward step.

He lifted Judgment high in the air, then leveled it at the unmoving figure.

"Come and face me yourself, coward," Garen said, under his breath. "Stop hiding behind your warriors."

As if the warden heard him, he turned abruptly, and disappeared from sight.

Garen stood staring at the enemy for long moments, then turned to rejoin his own ranks.

****

It had been half an hour since the last assault. The Demacians rested, as best they could, though all remained tense.

Cithria sat with her back against one of the bridge walls, exhausted, staring vacantly into the distance.

Finally, it seemed the enemy had grown tired of tripping over their own dead. Without ceremony, bodies were being dragged to the edge of the bridge and hauled over the side, falling to the rocks and whitewater below. It seemed a callous, ignoble end, even for those savage foes.

She heard a curse nearby, and turned to see Alys Morn kneeling over an injured soldier nearby. He was Eighth Shield, wounded in one of the earlier waves and dragged back from the front lines. Cithria didn't know his name. The massive figure of Sergeant Rosk was there too. He was holding the soldier down as Morn worked to save his life, but now he slumped back on his haunches, for the man had gone deathly still.

Morn swore again and stood up, her expression angry. Blood coated her hands.

It seemed to Cithria that the likelihood of any of them lasting till dawn was rapidly diminishing. Even if they did, there seemed little hope of surviving the next day.

"At least the rain's holding off," remarked Merrek. The sergeant sat nearby, looking old and gray.

Cithria glanced up. The thick rainclouds of the previous days had gone, revealing the crescent moon and sky full of stars overhead. Out of habit, she looked for the constellation of the Protector, locating it high in the north sky. Its presence always gave her comfort.

She frowned as she saw movement above, briefly making it seem as though the stars were flickering. A flight of bats? Realization dawned a fraction later, and her eyes widened.

“Shields up!” she roared, scrambling to her feet as a cloud of arrows descended on their position.

The Vanguard responded instantly, reacting to protect themselves as the arrows sliced down around them. Cithria crouched low under her shield. Three arrows struck it, each like a hammer blow. A second volley descended on them, and Cithria tried to make herself as small as possible beneath her shield. She stayed crouched low for a moment after the deadly shower was over, until she was certain no more were coming, then straightened and looked around.

“Aiguo,” she whispered.

She saw Merrek kneeling beside Aiguo. The veteran had an arrow embedded deep in his neck, having found the narrow gap between his pauldrons and helm, and punched through the mail beneath.

“Damn,” Aiguo gasped. Then he smiled, though it was perhaps more of a grimace than his usual, infectious grin. “Guess I… didn’t get my… shield up in time.”

Merrek held his hand, while Cithria and the other members of First Shield stood in silence nearby. Two more ragged breaths, and Aiguo was gone.

“I’m sorry, lad,” Merrek said in a low voice. “You deserved better.”

Eben Hess let out a cry of anger they all felt, and kicked a fallen enemy helmet into the darkness.

****

“Eyes up,” said Kriel, rising to his full, towering height and looking back

along the bridge. Like all of them, the massive Stonehorn was sporting numerous injuries. Several sword cuts on his arms and legs had been hastily stitched and bandaged by Morn, and his horns bore several new deep gouges in them. Those would become new scars of honor, were he to survive. Nothing could be done for his left ear, however, which had been sliced off in one of the exchanges.

Cithria moved to the Stonehorn's side, squinting through the gloom.

The silver moon had passed its zenith, and was now sinking toward the western horizon, in the direction of distant Demacia behind them. Movement stirred among the enemy ranks. Massive warriors bedecked in thick, black plate, they marched under a red flag, and the ground shuddered as they moved into position, and began to press through the gate tower onto the bridge.

"Different ones this time," Cithria said. "I think they're bringing the elite forward."

"The Noxian warden has run out of patience, it seems," observed Shield-Sergeant Merrek.

The Vanguard tightened their ranks around Garen once more, readying for what was to come.

"Look at yourselves and be proud, brothers and sisters of Demacia," Garen said. "You are heroes, all of you. Whoever comes at us, know that we are better. And if this is best they have, then Demacia has nothing to fear, not when there are those like you to defend it."

Cithria gripped her shield and sword tightly, standing taller at Garen's words. He was weary, and bloody, and disheveled, but he still looked like a hero of old, broad-shouldered and defiant. She would not let him down.

"If it is death they seek, I will bring it to them," swore Saskja Vos, her

eyes red.

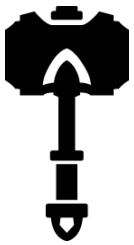
The enemy advanced, too numerous to count.

The elite warriors began slamming the butts of their weapons into the ground, creating a building, rhythmic din. They added their voices to the clamor, the sound deep and guttural. Their ranks parted suddenly, the warriors pressing out to either side to form a corridor.

A new figure appeared, stomping forward through the gate tower.

“What is *that*?” breathed Cithria.

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Chapter Ten

Clad in dark plate and furs and riding high on his saddle, the warrior was forced to duck in order to fit beneath the raised portcullis. The cheers of the warriors surrounding him told Cithria that he was some kind of barbaric warchief or champion.

The creature he rode was a gigantic slab of muscle and scale, easily ten feet tall at the shoulder, and perhaps five times that in length. Its reptilian body was thick and bulky, and overlapping plates of black iron had been hammered into its flesh. The rider held reins made of barbed chain, hooked through the flesh of his mount's broad, draconic face. In his other hand, the warchief held a long spear, tipped with a jagged blade.

"Basilisk," said Kriel. "Giant lizards of the southland, beyond Valoran. I have read of young ones being trained to be ridden, before they grow too large to handle."

"*Young ones*?" said Cithria. "You're saying this is a *baby*?"

"I believe the correct term is *hatchling*," said Kriel.

"I'd hate to see the mother," remarked Alys Morn.

The barbaric chieftain yanked cruelly on the chains, forcing his beast to halt. It snarled, thick strings of drool dripping from its maw. He looked up at the warden, watching from atop the tower, and raised his spear in salute. The warden slammed one of his armored fists into his chest in return, and the rider swung back toward waiting Demacians. He punched the air, waving his spear, and the chanting of his soldiers grew louder. Then he kicked his savagely spiked spurs into his great warbeast.

"Your books have any advice on how to kill this thing?" hissed Eben

Hess.

Kriel shrugged. “I imagine it dies like anything else.”

“Well, that sounds easy then,” sneered Hess.

“Enough,” said Garen. “We’ve seen off everything else they’ve thrown against us. We’ll see off this creature. And when it falls, it will demoralize them.”

The chieftain kicked the beast again, and it broke into a thunderous, loping run. The black-clad warriors closed ranks behind it, and followed in its wake.

“We are the shield of Demacia!” Garen roared, clutching the hilt of Judgment tightly, as the behemoth pounded toward their ranks. “Be ready, Vanguard!”

The chieftain uttered an ululating war cry, which drowned out a moment later, by the deafening roar of the charging beast. That terrifying, ear-splitting cry stole Cithria’s breath.

The sheer size of the basilisk became ever more apparent the closer it got —a mass of muscle, bred to break stone and smash through armor.

The Vanguard tightened their ranks, standing shoulder to shoulder, shields front, and braced for impact.

The basilisk roared again, lowering its iron-bedecked head as it barreled toward them, tiny red eyes wild, and massive clawed forelimbs tearing up stone.

Cithria stared wide eyed, her heart thundering. Every instinct screamed to turn and run. How could they possibly stand against such a creature?

“Hold!” bellowed Garen, as if hearing her doubt, just before the beast reached their line.

Cithria found herself shouting wordlessly—partly in defiance, partly in

fear—and leaned into her shield.

The basilisk struck with the force of a battering ram.

Armor and bone crunched, and Vanguard were sent flying as it ploughed into their ranks.

The soldier to Cithria's left—one of Fourth Shield—was trampled in the charge, his shield and armor proving utterly ineffective. His Demacian steel crumpled like an eggshell under a hammer, leaving him broken and bloodied. Half a dozen others were crushed or hurled aside as if they weighed nothing at all.

Cithria was shocked both by the sudden ferocity of the charge, and the fact she was still standing. She lashed out wildly, scoring a deep gouge in the monster's flank, but her sword was wrenched from her grasp. Pulled off balance, Cithria caught a glancing blow by one of the beast's massive forelegs as it swept past, slamming her back into Hess. The veteran snarled in frustration, pushing by her to strike.

Cithria fell to one knee, her shield arm numb from fingertips to shoulder.

The barbaric rider astride the basilisk thrust with his spear, and the jagged tip found Shield-Sergeant Rosk. The blow punched straight through his breastplate. Bellowing, the sergeant was lifted off his feet. With an almost dismissive flick, the rider threw him off the bridge, to fall into the darkness below.

Garen roared, lashing out with Judgment, hacking into the giant beast's flank as it thundered on. The blade dug deep, parting flesh and armor alike, spilling a torrent of black blood.

Bleeding from a dozen wounds, the beast roared in pain and veered to the side, crushing several Demacians against the crenelated side of the bridge. The impact cracked stone, sending another Vanguard tumbling to the

Silverrun far below amid chunks of masonry.

Cithria pushed herself unsteadily to her feet. Her shield was bent around her arm, and her blade still embedded in the basilisk.

“Cithria!” boomed Kriel, from nearby. “Move!”

She only dimly registered the warning, transfixed by the carnage. Too late, she saw the beast’s massive, iron-spiked tail swinging toward her, but she remained frozen, unable to move.

Hess slammed into her, hurling her aside just before the iron spikes impaled her. The veteran took the force of the blow in her stead, and was slammed into the side of the bridge with bone-breaking force. He crumpled to the ground, breastplate buckled inward.

Then the monster was past, having driven straight through the Vanguard formation.

In its wake, Demacians lay scattered across the bridge. Several lay still, while others groaned and struggled to regain their feet, bloodied, bruised, and dazed.

Breathing hard, Cithria looked over at Hess. It should have been her lying broken on the ground, not him. She’d frozen, and now, because of her weakness, one of First Shield’s best fighters had fallen.

She cast a worried glance further along the bridge. The enemy elite approached the shattered Demacian line, heavy polearms, axes, and hammers clutched in mailed hands. The war beast had served its purpose, smashing apart the Demacian bulwark. Now these killers would finish the job.

Looking the other way, she saw the chieftain behind the Vanguard, dragging on the chains, fighting to slow the monster and bring it back around. It fought against him, and bashed its armored head and spiked tail

against the sides of the bridge, sending cracks splintering out from the impacts.

Cithria scrambled over to Hess.

“Bastard thing,” he hissed. “Get me up.”

He was alive, at least for now. Cithria put an arm around him, helping him stand.

“I’m sorry,” she mumbled. “This is my fault.”

He grimaced, and didn’t reply. His face was gray, and as much as she knew he hated it, he wasn’t going to be able to stay on his feet without her support.

“Up! Up!” shouted Shield-Sergeant Kol. “Reform the line!”

Cithria glanced around her. More than half the Vanguard were down. There was no way they were going to hold.

“The basilisk?” said Cithria, glancing anxiously behind her.

“I’ll deal with the beast,” said Garen, grimly.

****

Garen stalked toward the massive lizard, eyes narrowing.

Its rider was trying to turn it, kicking it fiercely, and yanking on its chains. The beast was bleeding from a dozen wounds across its flanks, roaring and bucking, thick ropes of drool slavering from its maw.

Taking it while it was vulnerable was the best chance Garen had. The Vanguard would not be able to withstand another charge. It had to die now.

Garen broke into a sprint, Judgment clasped in both hands.

The chieftain atop the monster saw him coming, and struck the beast with his spear, but still it remained indomitable. It snapped up at its master, trying in vain to reach one of his legs and rip him down to the ground.

That was all the time Garen needed to close the distance.

He reversed his grip on his broadsword, point leveled at the monster's thick neck, and placed the palm of one hand against its pommel. Grunting with effort, he rammed the blade into the basilisk's flesh, driving it in deep with all his weight.

The beast went wild, screeching in pain and rage. Judgment was embedded to the crossguard in its thick neck, and Garen clung on doggedly, refusing to relinquish his grip. The violent thrashing of the basilisk snapped one of its chains, and now, utterly uncontrollable, it took off down the bridge. It shook its heavy head from side to side, oblivious to what lay in its path, and Garen was dragged along with it.

The chieftain stabbed at him with his spear, snarling, even as he struggled to stay saddled, but the wild movement of his war beast thwarted his aim. The barbed tip of his weapon ricocheted harmlessly off Garen's shoulder plate, barely scratching the Demacian steel.

Instead of striking again, the chieftain uttered a sudden bark of alarm. With one sharp movement, he kicked free of his saddle, hitting the ground in a roll.

Garen looked up, and his eyes widened an instant before the basilisk slammed into the corner of the gate tower.

****

The battered remnants of the Vanguard were all interspersed now; all who could fight stood together, awaiting the inevitable charge.

The enemy elite advanced steadily toward them. What little skin Cithria could glimpse beneath their dark plate was covered in tattoos and warpaint. Even their braided beards were daubed with flaking red paint. Drums

pounded in their midst, the sound savage and unnerving, blurring with the grunting chant of the Noxians as they stomped forward.

“Come on, you bastards,” hissed Saskja Vos, her voice hoarse.

Cithria stared at them, pushing back the panic rising within her.

“Steady,” growled Merrek, at her side. “We are the Vanguard. We *hold*.”

There was a thunderous crack of metal on stone behind them, and the whole bridge shuddered as if under the effect of an earthquake.

“What the…” breathed Cithria, not daring to take her eyes off the oncoming enemy.

She tightened her grip on her horribly bent shield, and readied her sword. If this was to be the last, defiant moment of their resistance, she was going to take down as many of these enemies as possible.

However this was to end, she would not freeze up again.

****

Quinn’s eyes flicked open as the tower shook beneath her, swaying with a colossal impact.

A corner of the tower broke away with a sharp crack, toppling into the darkness below. She heard shouts and roars nearby, and struggled to rise.

The pain hit her, and she gasped, doubling over and clutching at her side. Her vision wavered, but a nearby voice penetrated the fog of agony.

Garen.

With a gasp, Quinn pushed herself to her knees. Her crossbow lay nearby, and she snatched it up as she dragged herself up toward the parapet.

****

Garen clung to the stone of the bridge with one hand, dangling

precariously over its shattered edge. Below, the basilisk flailed in the air, roaring and twisting as it fell, along with a substantial chunk of the tower and bridge wall, into the whitewater of the Silverrun.

He held Judgment in his other hand—he had ripped it free of the immense war beast as it toppled over the brink. He tossed it up over the edge, hearing it clatter to the stone, and prepared to pull himself up. A figure appeared, dark against the moon.

The chieftain scowled down at him. He said something in his harsh, guttural tongue, and lifted his spear.

Just as Garen braced for the strike, he heard the hiss of fletching, followed by a flash of blue. The looming warrior staggered, dropping his spear and clutching at the bolt now embedded deep in his neck. Garen took advantage of the distraction and hauled himself up onto the bridge.

Despite the bolt jutting from his neck, and with blood spitting from his lips, the chieftain slid a knife from his belt, and lunged at Garen. The sword-captain slapped the blade away, knocking his enemy off balance, then punched him square in the throat.

The chieftain reeled, his windpipe crushed.

Even then, he did not fall, and his eyes blazed with stubborn fury. Garen retrieved Judgment, hefting it in both hands, and waited.

The warrior came at him in a rush. Garen dropped to one knee and slashed Judgment across the chieftain’s midsection, even as the knife arced harmlessly over his head.

The Noxian staggered another few steps, then collapsed to the bridge, finally dead.

****

The scattered remnants of the Vanguard stood firm, awaiting the charge that would end their dogged resistance once and for all… but it never came.

As the enemy saw their chieftain fall, their echoing chants and rhythmic drumming surged to deafening intensity, and then suddenly ceased. In the silence, Cithria could hear the Silverrun's roar below.

The Noxians stood motionless.

Then, as one, they lifted their weapons high in salute. They stood that way for a moment, then without further sound, turned and marched back the way they had come.

Saskja Vos glared after them, breathing hard. For a moment, Cithria thought she was going to give chase, to force them to keep fighting.

"Ease up, Saskja," said Merrek, placing a hand on her shoulder. She seemed to deflate, all her rage flowing out of her. She gave the shield-sergeant a nod, and turned away. All that was left now was grief and sadness.

"What are they doing?" said Cithria, staring after the retreating enemy. "If they'd kept pushing, they would have had us."

"Honoring their fallen chieftain," said Kriel.

"You think it's over?" said Cithria, hopefully.

Merrek shook his head.

"No," he said. "But it will be soon, one way or another."

****

Garen turned his gaze up to the top of the tower, where the bolt that had undoubtedly saved his life had come from. His breath caught in his throat as he saw who was up there.

"Quinn?" he whispered.

A cold feeling of dread filled him.

The ranger-knight's crossbow fell from her grasp as she faltered, and she tipped forward over the crenellations.

With a desperate cry, Garen hurled himself forward, sliding to his knees, and caught her in his arms before she hit the unforgiving stone.

Her skin was deathly gray, and her eyes half open. She looked up at Garen, struggling to focus.

"Should have… confirmed the kill," she breathed. "I… failed…"

Garen laid her down gently on the ground. Her leathers were dark and slick with blood—a *lot* of blood.

She was cold, and Garen unhooked his cloak, laying it over her. He glanced back along the bridge, and stopped short.

The enemy were *retreating*. It made no sense.

"You saved my life, ranger-knight," he said. "I owe you. Again."

Quinn clutched at him, her eyes feverish. "Valor…" she said, but whatever she was trying to say devolved into an ugly, rattling cough. Blood flecked her lips.

"Don't try to speak," said Garen.

Then she went limp, her head lolling to the side, and her eyes rolled back.

****

Eben Hess was propped against the side of the bridge among the other injured and dead, fumbling at the releases of his sundered breastplate. Alys Morn rushed over, dropping to her knees to assess the damage.

Cithria hovered nearby, watching. She'd seen the force of the blow that had struck him—the blow meant for her.

She hung her head. Hess might not exactly have been likeable, but he had

earned his place in First Shield, and was one of its best fighters. She'd let them all down. She'd let her fear overcome her in the midst of battle, and now he was going to die because of her hesitation.

Perhaps Morn had been right. She was out of her depth. She didn't belong here.

Morn slapped Hess' hands away, and took over releasing his buckles. He hissed as she eased the crumpled breastplate away from him.

"What in the name of the Protector?" said Morn, leaning in and narrowing her eyes.

"Is it bad?" said Hess.

Morn lifted up a pouch, heavy with coin. Coins were spilling out through a rent in its side. Cithria bent down and picked one of them off the ground. It was wrenched out of shape.

"Hess, you lucky swine," said Morn.

The injured soldier gave her a grim smile and snatched the pouch back. His expression changed a second later, however, as Morn probed at his ribs, not even making an effort to be gentle. He hissed in pain, but Morn leveled a finger at him.

"Quit your whining and sit still!" she snapped. "You might not be dead, but you're still injured."

Hess opened his mouth to say something, but clearly thought better of it, and stayed silent.

"You've got five broken ribs," Morn said, matter-of-factly. "Perhaps six. And your sternum is fractured."

"I can still fight," Hess said, sullenly.

"I didn't say you couldn't," said Morn. "Though it will hurt like hell, and you risk doing yourself more serious harm."

“Better than sitting here, waiting to die,” said Hess.

“I agree,” said Morn. “We’ll bind them tight. You might succumb to internal bleeding, but it’s the best I can offer.”

“I’m beginning to see why you didn’t last long with the Illuminators,” Hess said, under his breath.

A shout made them all look up.

“Morn! I need you here!”

Cithria stood, peering through the gloom.

“It’s the sword-captain,” she said.

Morn nodded. As she stood, she scooped up several coins that had spilled from Hess’ pouch. She pocketed some, and handed Cithria the rest.

“Hey, those’re mine!” protested Hess.

“We’ll just call it payment for medical aid,” said Morn, standing and turning away.

“But you didn’t do anything yet!” snapped Hess. He tried to rise, but gasped in pain and sank back to the ground.

“*Future* aid, then,” Morn said over her shoulder, with a smirk. “Cithria, come with me. I might have need of an extra pair of hands.”

Cithria was forced to jog to keep up with Morn as they made their way toward Garen. As they got closer, she could see Garen was not alone.

“Oh no,” whispered Cithria.

Quinn laid on the ground before Garen, and she didn’t look good. And the fact she was still here meant…

“Guess word didn’t get out after all,” muttered Morn. “That’s that, then.”

Morn pushed the captain out of the way, and dropped to her knees beside the deathly pale ranger-knight. Cithria watched on, biting her lip, as Morn checked the unconscious woman’s pulse and breathing. She probed at

Quinn’s blood-soaked leathers.

“I need water and bandages, girl,” Morn said.

Cithria unhooked her cloak and unsheathed her knife, even as Garen called for water. She had dreamed all her life of the day she would don the Vanguard’s blue, but didn’t hesitate as she started cutting the cloak into shreds.

Morn deftly sliced away Quinn’s leathers, exposing the ugly wound in her ribcage. She took a waterskin from Garen and cleaned it as best she could. Once the worst of the blood was wiped away, Cithria saw the puncture wound was quite small, though the flesh around it was an angry purple, and fresh blood already leaked from the wound.

“Crossbow puncture,” noted Morn, as she worked. “Put pressure here. Use one of your bandages.”

Cithria did as she was bid, while Morn produced a needle from a pouch at her hip, and threaded it neatly, holding it up to the moon for light. At a nod, Cithria released her hold, and Morn sealed up the wound with half a dozen neat stitches. Next, she unstoppered a small bottle and smeared a dark, waxy substance onto the wound, before she had Cithria help bind it with the freshly cut bandages.

“Will she live?” said Garen.

Morn shrugged, wiping blood off her hands. “I’m surprised she’s alive at all, to be honest, but she’s a tough one. If she makes it to morning, then she might have got lucky and suffered no serious internal damage. But the chances are slim.”

Garen looked troubled, and nodded distractedly as Morn told him she needed to check on the other injured soldiers.

“What was that stuff you put on the wound?” said Cithria, walking with

Morn as she checked each of the injured in turn.

“A salve made with honey and herbs, used by the Illuminators,” said Morn. “Helps reduce the chance of infection.”

“Why *did* you leave the order?” ventured Cithria, her curiosity overcoming her fear of overstepping. “They must have valued your skills highly, and wanted you to stay.”

“Truthfully?” said Alys Morn. “I was expelled in disgrace.”

“What?” gasped Cithria. “Why?”

“A soldier in my care put his hand under my robe,” said Morn, “so I broke his arm, and threw him out onto the street.”

Cithria snorted in surprise and delight. “Really?”

Morn flashed Cithria a rare grin.

“Well, the head of my hospice didn’t find it so amusing,” she said. “But the soldier was demoted and posted to Graygate for his trouble, and his shield-sergeant came to see me the next day. Offered me a place in the ranks. So it worked out.”

Morn’s expression hardened suddenly, the moment of levity passing as she knelt beside a still soldier. Cithria felt a pang of guilt for having been laughing a moment earlier. The soldier—Jowan, a Vanguard only a year or two older than her—had been alive just minutes earlier. Alys Morn gently closed his eyes.

“Cithria,” said a voice.

She turned to see Shield-Sergeant Merrek standing nearby, and she quickly stood to attention and saluted.

“No need for that,” he said, waving her to relax. “I’ve got a task for you. If you can spare her, Morn?”

“She’s all yours.”

****

The silver moon had long disappeared over the horizon and the sky was brightening in the east as the Vanguard waited in silence.

The previous evening's mist had returned with the morning light, muffling all sound. From Alderburg, indistinct torchlight dimly pierced the gloom.

Cithria walked out of the mist, approaching the Vanguard lines. Those on watch tensed, then relaxed a moment later as they recognized her.

She found Merrek, who nodded in Garen's direction, and they approached their sword-captain together.

Garen sat near the motionless figure of Quinn, brooding. Judgment was unsheathed across his lap. Merrek cleared his throat, and Garen looked up.

In that brief, unguarded moment, he looked so lonely and vulnerable. He was such an awe-inspiring presence that it was easy to forget he was still just a young man. Then the moment was past, and Cithria saw the stoic and unyielding sword-captain once more, as if a mask had been brought down over his face.

"You're back," Garen said. "What did you see?"

"The mist concealed my approach, sword-captain, but I don't think they would have much cared if they *had* seen me," said Cithria. "They don't seem to be in any rush, but they're gathering again. Same big, armored ones as before. Looks like they'll make another push before sunrise."

Garen nodded, as if he expected as much. "And the warden?"

"He's out of the tower, down among the warriors massing just beyond the bridge tower," said Cithria. "He's arguing with them. I think he wanted them to attack right away…"

Garen pondered this for a moment, his expression thoughtful. Then he stood, as if coming to a decision. “Gather the Shields,” he said, his eyes burning with sudden intensity. “Everyone who can fight.”

“You think they will attack immediately?” said Merrek.

“No,” said Garen. “But we’ve done enough defending. It is time to cut the head off this snake.”

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Chapter Eleven

The Vanguard ran through the haze, moving fast, the clatter of their armor deadened by the fog. There were no battle cries, no rousing speeches. Just the last of the Demacians able to fight, moving unseen, like silver-sheened ghosts.

Garen led the way, with Kriel and Alys Morn a step behind him. The rest trailed close, forming an arrowhead.

Despite the pain and death of the previous night, Cithria grinned as she ran. After endless waves of enemy attacks through the night, they were finally striking back. It was likely they would all die, but at least they would do so on their own terms. All Cithria's fears were cast aside in that adrenaline-fueled, euphoric charge.

The gatehouse loomed ahead, a vague shadow in the gloom.

At any moment, Cithria expected the alarm to be raised. To her ears, the sound of her armor and weapons was deafening, but still there was no shout of warning. And every moment they were not challenged brought them one step closer to taking the enemy by surprise.

Perhaps a desperate assault was the last thing they expected. Perhaps they were just complacent, and the sentries atop the tower were dozing at their posts.

The Vanguard raced along the full length of the bridge unopposed, and were within a dozen yards of the gatehouse before a belated, confused shout finally sounded. Then the Vanguard were at the tower, sprinting into the shadow of the archway beneath it, and under the great iron portcullis, which loomed above like an executioner's axe.

More shouts sounded. Cithria could see the warriors massing in the mud beyond the gateway.

A soldier wearing Nockmirch colors stepped into their path, halberd raised, but Garen barely slowed, knocking the axe blade of the polearm aside with one movement, and hacking the man down with another.

Then they were through the gate, and racing down the embankment beyond, straight toward the figure of Warden Vigrid, who was bellowing orders.

Black-armored Noxians stepped to meet them.

“Demacia!” roared Garen, charging.

“Demacia!” shouted Cithria, hurling herself forward in his wake.

Then the Vanguard were among the enemy, and the killing began anew.

****

Garen cut down the first of the enemy warriors with a powerful swing, hacking him fully in half. As that one fell, Garen spun, continuing his momentum, his great silver blade scything around, cutting down two more before they could even raise weapons.

A step ahead of the Vanguard, he had no need to restrain himself. He was surrounded by enemies, and he slashed his massive blade left and right, carving through them with abandon, gaze fixed firmly on the warden.

A heavy war-axe took him in the shoulder, driving him to one knee, but he did not allow his charge to falter. He pushed back to his feet, grunting with effort, and drove his broadsword’s point into the warrior who’d struck him, guiding the strike with one hand wrapped around the blade, halfway down. He ran the man through, then kicked him away, freeing his sword. A polearm, wickedly bladed, flashed in the periphery of his vision, angling for

his head, but it was turned aside by young Cithria, who dispatched the warrior wielding it with a lightning-quick stab into the neck.

Damn, she is fast, Garen thought, looking behind him.

The other surviving members of First Shield made a good account of themselves. Alys Morn killed with her usual cold efficiency, in constant motion, her sword dancing. Eben Hess threw himself into the enemy with a blade in each hand, hacking with abandon, unslowed by his injuries. Saskja Vos had given herself over to a burning fury, savagely cutting down everything in her path. Kriel was an unstoppable force, ignoring the axes and swords that sliced into him and sending enemies flying with every blow. And the solid, familiar figure of old Merrek, who'd given Garen his first opportunity in the Vanguard, went about his business with his usual lack of flourish. It was easy to forget how good a fighter he was, for he was anything but glamorous, but he killed effectively and was as tough as anyone in the ranks.

Then Garen was through the last of the enemy separating him from his target, and came face to face with Vigrid.

"You've fought well, sword-captain," said the warden, hefting a long-hafted warhammer in his gauntleted hands. A wicked spike jutted out behind the hammer's head, counter-balancing its weight. "In better circumstances, we might have been battle-brothers. It would have been an honor to fight alongside you, shoulder to shoulder."

"You *have* no honor," hissed Garen.

Vigrid sighed.

"Just not as you understand it, captain," said Vigrid, with a thoughtful shrug.

Garen grunted with effort as he swung Judgment, bringing it around in a

slicing arc. The warden met it with the grip of his hammer, holding it like a quarterstaff. The haft was made of black steel, and Garen's sword rang off it sharply, sparks flying.

The warden twisted the haft and jabbed the spiked pommel at Garen's face. He moved fast for a man of his size, and Garen barely avoided the sudden thrust. He turned, side-stepping to give himself additional space, but was forced to retreat as the warden swung his hammer after him, putting his full force into the blow.

Garen went on the attack, striking high, then low. Both blows were met by the warden's iron hammer.

Around them, the battle raged, but Garen saw nothing but the Noxian before him.

The warden hooked his hammer behind one of Garen's knees, dragging him off balance, then stepped in close and slammed his forehead into Garen's face.

Blinding pain obscured Garen's vision as his nose shattered. Sensing more than seeing the next blow, he staggered back, raising Judgment. The hammer slammed into his blade, almost smashing it from his grasp. He reeled, staggered by the power of the strike.

Then the full weight of the hammerhead slammed down onto one of Garen's shoulders. It drove him to his knees, crumpling his pauldron and crunching bone.

Few soldiers would have been able to recover from such a blow, and it was clear from the warden's expression that he did not expect his opponent to rise. Yet Garen gritted his teeth against the pain, enduring it, and pushed back to his feet.

Vigrid gave him a nod of grudging respect, his expression betraying his

surprise, then struck again.

This time, Garen was too slow.

The hammer took him square in the chest, buckling the plate, and knocking him off his feet. He hit the ground with a crash, struggling for breath. Even so, he pushed himself back up again.

“Is that all you’ve got?” he managed, though he could barely stand.

“You just don’t know when you’re beaten, do you?” said Vigrid.

Garen raised Judgment into the path of the next strike that came at him, but his strength was gone, and he was driven to the ground once more, dropping to one knee.

Bloodied, broken, and exhausted, his armor a dented ruin, this time he stayed down.

“For all your pride, you and your soldiers are going to die here,” Vigrid said, flipping the hammer around. “The story of your last stand will never reach Demacia. And when the time is right, your nation will bow before the might of Noxus, as will all of Valoran.”

Through his swimming vision he saw the warden draw back his hammer, spike first, for the killing blow.

With a sudden surge, Garen summoned a last, desperate reserve of energy. With a roar, he rose to his feet, and drove Judgment up into the warden’s body. It slid between his heavy iron plating, and drove through the chain links beneath, scraping between ribs.

“Demacia will never bend the knee,” Garen snarled.

Vigrid dropped his hammer and gripped Garen around the neck, pressing his armored thumbs into his throat, even as his own life-blood flowed from him. He snarled, blood on his lips. Garen gagged, and pushed his blade further, driving it completely through the Noxian. Still, Vigrid choked him,

determined to take him with him into death's embrace.

Garen put the flat of one boot upon the warden's chest and shoved him back, breaking away from him and sliding his sword free. The blood on the blade ran off instantly, leaving Judgment pristine and shining.

The warden collapsed to his knees. Dying, he looked up at Garen.

"You would have made a good warrior of the Trifarian Legion," he said.

Garen stood glaring down at him. The warden's eyes were growing vague, as if seeing things that were not there. Vigrid smiled at whatever vision he saw.

"The Wolf comes," he breathed. "This is… a good… death."

****

The Vanguard were surrounded. If they had hoped the enemy would have been stunned into submission by the death of the warden, they were mistaken. The iron-clad warriors closed in, hacking and cutting. The Demacians formed an ever-tightening circle, determined to resist the end as long as they were able, and to take as many Noxians as possible with them.

Cithria's arms were leaden, and her breathing was labored. She knew she was injured, but she didn't feel any pain, just exhaustion. The end was close.

But as the first rays of dawn pierced the mist, a keening cry echoed overhead.

"Protector above…" breathed Merrek, raising his blood-covered face toward the light.

The Noxians took a step back, suddenly uneasy, allowing Cithria time to glance skyward.

An eagle circled overhead. Its feathers were a deep blue, and its wingspan

was broad… yet it was dwarfed by what followed, hurtling down through the clouds.

“Raptors!” exclaimed Cithria, hope surging.

There was a score of the majestic creatures, each ridden by a Demacian knight bedecked in glittering brightsteel, and they dove down into the enemy, wings furled, lances lowered.

They smashed through the enemy ranks, raptors killing with snapping beaks and rending, sword-like talons, their riders impaling foes on silver lances. Some of the immense creatures landed briefly, sending enemies sprawling, their serpentine necks whipping as they lunged in for kills. Then they lifted off again, smashing Noxians aside and breaking limbs with their powerful wings.

The enemy broke. Within moments, it was a rout.

“It’s over?” said Cithria, sinking to her knees.

“It’s over,” nodded Merrek.

****

Exhausted and spattered with blood—she wasn’t sure how much of it was her own—Cithria stared around her in numb disbelief at how suddenly her fate had shifted.

The Noxian warhost had scattered eastward out the gates of Alderburg, and were being harried by the raptor knights. The surviving soldiers of the Nockmirch knelt in rows before the bloodied Vanguard.

A number of raptors had been slain in the battle, their broken forms now lying motionless in the mud within the walls of Alderburg. In the air, they were so powerful and noble, but on the ground, lifeless, they seemed infinitely delicate. She had taken a feather from one of the fallen creatures,

giving it silent thanks for its sacrifice—with each of their deaths, it felt to Cithria, the world had lost a little of its wonder.

She stood guard over the Nockmirch soldiers with her companions, but she expected no trouble from them. Even with the Noxians gone, the Demacians were still outnumbered easily ten to one, but the Nockmirchers had lost their will to fight, burned away like the morning's mist. Having thrown down their weapons, they knelt silently, shame-faced, and awaited their fate.

At their head, Lord Eldwyn glared at Garen, old and full of bitterness, but upright. Lady Odelyn stood stiffly at his side, her face was grim and her head high.

"The mage," growled Garen. "The one posing as our ambassador. Where is it?"

"Slipped off during the battle, as I understand it," said Lady Odelyn. "We are as shocked as you to learn they were an imposter. Had we known, we would have seen them dragged to Demacia in chains long ago."

"The illusion was convincing," said Garen. "But that does not absolve you of blame, Lord Eldwyn. You knowingly allied yourself with the enemy."

"And if I did not, my lands would now be burning, my people dying!" said Eldwyn. "We asked for Demacia's aid. It never came."

"No word was ever received." Garen pinched the bridge of his nose, closing his eyes. "Let me guess. Those requests for aid were sent by our ambassador?"

Lady Odelyn nodded. Cithria glanced along the line of dejected Nockmirch soldiers, and the depleted Vanguard ranks. There'd been so much death; was it truly all because of a misunderstanding, carefully

manufactured by the Noxians? It made her feel sick to the stomach.

“Sword-captain, I know that I am not in a position to make requests of you, but I would make one nevertheless,” said Lady Odelyn.

“Let’s hear it,” said Garen.

“Spare these soldiers,” she said, gesturing toward the kneeling lines. “This *madness* was none of their doing.”

“It would have been madness to resist the Noxians!” barked her father.

“Mother would never have allowed you to spit on your oaths,” Odelyn snapped back at him. “She would have wanted us to fight, to our last drop of blood if necessary!”

Lord Eldwyn shrank a little at the mention of his dead wife.

“And what punishment do you think is suitable for your father, who is responsible for this situation?” growled Garen.

The Lord of the Nockmirch dropped to his knees in the mud. It seemed all the fight had gone out of him.

“Just end it,” he said, in a small voice. “Don’t draw this out any longer than is necessary. Finish it, here and now. Allow me to join my wife.”

Lady Odelyn looked down at her father with what looked to Cithria as a mix of pity and loathing.

“He was not always like this,” she said, addressing Garen. “My mother was the strong one, and when she passed, it broke him. That’s when the warden wormed his way into my father’s trust.”

Cithria looked down at the Lord of the Nockmirch. He certainly didn’t look a danger now… yet his actions had caused so many deaths.

“He is my father,” said Lady Odelyn, in a quiet voice, “but I will not beg for his life.”

With a hiss of metal, Garen drew Judgment, righteous anger simmering in

his eyes.

Lord Eldwyn lowered his head, exposing the back of his neck.

Garen's blade hovered above Lord Eldwyn's neck. Lady Odelyn watched on, pale and unwavering.

Cithria did not expect Garen to be merciful, not after the bloody night they had just endured. It did seem grievously unfair to Cithria for Eldwyn to live when so many had died because of his choices, but what would his death achieve other than more pain, resentment, and shame? She had no doubt he had done what he thought best for the safety of his people. Could he really be condemned for that?

Garen turned his head, looking around at all the gathered soldiers, Demacian and Nockmirch. His gaze met Cithria's, and he paused.

Then he sighed and stepped back.

"Cithria," Garen said, indicating for her to come forward.

"Sword-captain?" said Cithria, feeling a hundred pairs of eyes suddenly lock on to her.

She stepped warily forward, and cast a quick glance over at Merrek, who gave a near-imperceptible nod in response to her silent question.

What's going on?

Garen ushered her aside, and spoke to her in a quiet voice, so they wouldn't be overheard.

"What do you make of the lord's daughter?" Garen said.

"The Lady Odelyn?"

Garen nodded. "Tell me what you see."

"Strong and proud," said Cithria, "even now, with her family's honor in tatters. She is ready to face… whatever comes next. I would hazard a guess she takes more after her mother than Lord Eldwyn. She seems more

composed. More… rational."

Garen nodded, thoughtful. Cithria opened her mouth to say more, then bit her lip, wondering if she was stepping out of line. But the sword-captain had asked her opinion, so it was her duty to give it.

"It seems to me the Lord of the Nockmirch's grief and fear have been cruelly manipulated," she said. "It was *Noxus* who orchestrated this."

"True. But he betrayed his oaths of allegiance," said Garen. "He is not blameless."

"He is not," agreed Cithria, "but it is our choice how we respond. And that choice will affect not only how the Nockmirch views Demacia, but all our allies."

Garen grunted, still deep in thought.

"Thank you," he said, finally, and motioned for her to rejoin her Shield.

Still confused, Cithria watched as Garen walked back to the cowering Lord of the Nockmirch. The anger in him seemed to have faded. Now, he just looked weary.

With a slow, deliberate movement, he sheathed Judgment. "There's been too much death here already," he said.

Lady Odelyn's face remained expressionless, but Cithria could see she was struggling to maintain her composure.

"I do not wish to see the Nockmirch suffer further," continued Garen, "and I would not have the actions of one man destroy an alliance that has stood for hundreds of years. He will live, but on two conditions."

Lady Odelyn squared her shoulders. "Name them," she said.

"First, your father abdicates his seat, and will never again have any part in the running of the Nockmirch."

"And the second?"

“*You* take his seat, rule as your mother would have done, and remember who your friends are. Demacia will *always* come to the aid of its allies.”

“No woman has ever ruled the Nockmirch,” mused Lady Odelyn. “The law—”

“The law be damned,” snapped Garen. He turned, glowering around him, and raised his voice to be heard by all. “If there is any man in the Nockmirch who would refuse the Lady Odelyn as your ruler, stand forth now!”

Garen turned on the spot, seeking anyone who would dare oppose the lady’s rule, but there was none. After a moment Garen turned back to Lady Odelyn.

“Times change,” he said, “and we must all change with them.”

“Never again will the Nockmirch bow the knee, to Noxus or anyone,” Odelyn swore. “And we will always honor our alliance.”

There was steel in her voice, and Cithria believed her.

“Your soldiers need training,” Garen said. “Strength through discipline. They will need to be reforged and tempered before Noxus returns, and have no doubt that it will. But when they do, Demacia will stand with you, as your ally and friend. My Dauntless Vanguard will help train your troops for the war to come. Our battlesmiths will ensure you carry good steel, and our masons will strengthen your fortifications in the east. You do not stand alone. Not now, not ever.”

“Thank you, sword-captain,” said Lady Odelyn, bowing her head. “It is more than we could have hoped for.”

Garen shook his head.

“Not everything your father said was wrong. The Nockmirch has long protected the approach to Demacia, and borne the brunt of attacks from the

east. It is only right for us to repay that vigilance, and fight at your side when the time comes."

In that moment—for all the tragedy that had befallen her kingdom in recent times, perhaps in part due to its own failings—Cithria felt incredibly proud to be Demacian.

"Give me back my coin," snarled a familiar voice, interrupting her thoughts. "I ain't forgotten."

Cithria looked around, and saw Eben Hess, his chest heavily strapped. He was staring balefully at her.

"It ain't yours to keep," he growled.

Cithria shrank under his glare, and reached for her pouch.

"She's not giving you anything, Hess," said Alys Morn, interrupting. The veteran was standing nearby, arms crossed. "And nor am I."

Hess' scowl deepened, his face going red as his gaze flicked back and forth between them. Finally, he cursed under his breath and stomped away.

Cithria breathed out. "Thank you," she said.

Morn gave her a curt nod.

"I may have misjudged you, Cloudfield," she said, turning away. "You'll do."

****

Garen turned and gave a last look at Alderburg as he and the depleted Dauntless Vanguard began the journey back home.

Two wagons pulled by oxen accompanied the Demacians, carrying those whose injuries were such that they could not walk, and the bodies of the fallen, laid out upon their shields, their blue cloaks draped over them. They would be borne back to the capital with honor, and interred with the other

heroes of the kingdom.

In the distance, the massive, horned figure of Kriel raised a hand in farewell. Garen had chosen him to stay behind, to oversee matters in the Nockmirch until an official deputation from Demacia was appointed to the role. The Nockmirch would have need of the Stonehorn's quiet wisdom in the days ahead as it sought to rebuild its strength.

This had not been a true Noxian invasion. It had been little more than an advance force, probing westward, testing the defenses.

Garen breathed in deeply.

A red-eyed raven stood upon one of the battlements nearby, watching. It croaked, the sound ugly and hateful, then took wing, flying eastward.

War was coming.

And Demacia would be ready.

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Chapter Twelve

Sunset was drawing in as Cithria sat alone in the empty training ground, sharpening the blade of her sword with a whetstone. It was the same training ground where she'd first met Garen, back before they'd left for the Nockmirch.

Has it really only been a matter of weeks?

They had arrived back in the capital the day before, receiving a heroes' welcome. She'd felt strangely numbed by the experience, as if she was observing the tossed garlands of flowers and the cheering crowds through the eyes of someone else.

It wasn't long ago that she'd been in that crowd, celebrating the victorious return of the Dauntless Vanguard from campaign, and dreaming of one day joining their illustrious ranks. She'd idolized those soldiers, all impossibly large and stoic, clad in their impenetrable steel, their blue cloaks pristine and perfect.

But now that she was on the other side, having endured that harrowing night on the bridge between Rijenland and the Nockmirch, and witnessed the ugly deaths of so many soldiers far more experienced than her, the parade just seemed… meaningless.

Of course, she'd been a soldier long enough to know the reality of battle rarely matched the stories.

War meant being cold and hungry, exhausted from long marches, and sore from sleeping on rough ground. It meant mind-numbing boredom, interspersed with sudden moments of terrifying violence.

Death was rarely heroic, no matter what the histories claimed. More often

it was pointless, ignominious, and random, like Aiguo, felled by a stray arrow. It was blood and pain and misery. And the role and nature of the Dauntless Vanguard meant it always sought out the most difficult, punishing, and uncompromising battlefields.

On the journey back, Cithria had questioned more than once why she had longed to join their ranks.

“You know we have battlesmiths for that, don’t you?”

Cithria looked up to see Shield-Sergeant Merrek looking down at her. She made to stand to attention, but he waved her to remain seated and carry on.

“I’m sure the battlesmiths would do a better job of it, sergeant, but…” Cithria shrugged. “Old habits.”

“Don’t let me interrupt,” he said. “I was just on my way out when I saw you over here.”

Cithria gave him a ghost of a smile, and looked down the length of her blade, assessing it, before continuing with her slow work.

“You mind?” said Merrek, gesturing to the step beside her.

“Please,” she said.

The shield-sergeant sat with an exaggerated groan. He pulled out a small flask and unstoppered it. He offered it to her, but she declined with a slight shake of her head. He took a swig, and let out a contented sigh.

They settled into a comfortable silence, broken only by the slow scrape of the whetstone.

The sun slowly dipped over the horizon, casting long shadows across the sparring grounds.

“Oh, I have something for you,” said Merrek, sitting forward and reaching into one of the deep pockets of his cloak. He pulled out a small wood carving, and handed it to her.

Cithria put down her blade and whetstone, her eyes widening as she took it from Merrek, holding it gingerly in both hands. It was a small raptor in full flight, carved from a single piece of dark wood. Its beak was open in a silent cry, and its wings were pulled back in a dive. It really did perfectly capture the fierce essence of a raptor, and she marveled at its craftsmanship.

“It’s wonderful,” she breathed.

“Kriel made it for you,” he said. “Sent it from the Nockmirch, along with his dispatches.”

“Kriel made this?” said Cithria.

“I don’t know how he does it, with those giant hands of his,” said Merrek. “But he is Stonehorn.”

“It’s perfect,” she said, holding it up to the sky, so that it looked like it was flying.

“Anyway, I just wanted to make sure I passed it on, before I forgot,” said Merrek. He pushed himself back to his feet with another exaggerated groan.

“I’ll treasure it,” said Cithria.

Merrek looked down at her. “You’re a good soldier, Cithria of Cloudfield,” he said. “We’re lucky to have you in First Shield.”

Cithria felt her cheeks redden.

“I froze,” she blurted. “On the bridge, against the basilisk—I froze, and would have died if Hess hadn’t knocked me aside. He took the blow meant for me, and was almost killed. I… I don’t deserve…”

She cut herself short, and looked down. Merrek didn’t say anything in reply. She knew he was disappointed. He’d recruited her, and spoken up for her, and she’d *failed* him.

He nodded, considering.

“You have any idea how many times I’ve been saved by another member

of First Shield?” he said, after a moment. “How many times one of them has taken a hit meant for me?”

Cithria didn’t reply.

“It’s what we do,” said Merrek. “We protect each other.”

“But I—”

“Being Vanguard doesn’t make you faultless, but we don’t make the same mistake twice. Freeze up again, and we’ll talk,” said Merrek. “But I don’t think you will. You’re one of us, after all.”

“I…” said Cithria. Merrek lifted an eyebrow, as if daring her to disagree with him. “Yes, sergeant,” she said, finally.

Merrek nodded.

Cithria sat for a moment longer after he had left, cradling the wooden raptor.

And with no little surprise, Cithria dared to start believing First Shield was where she was meant to be.

****

Garen stood to attention before High Marshal Tianna Crownguard.

He wore a simple blue tabard bearing the winged sword emblem of their family, and for the first time in what felt like months, he was clean shaven. His left arm was held in a sling, his shoulder tightly bound in bandages and wraps. It felt strange not wearing his armor, as if he were missing a part of himself.

“Your wounds?” said Tianna, from behind her desk.

“Healing,” said Garen.

She regarded him with her cold, analytical gaze. He resisted the urge to look away.

“And how is your state of mind, sword-captain?” she said.

“Focused,” said Garen.

“Good to hear it.”

His jaw tightened.

“You did well, Garen,” said Tianna. “You realize that, don’t you?”

“I…” he said, unsure, at first, how to answer. “I lost soldiers. I should have done better.”

“It’s a minor miracle *any* of you survived, to be frank,” said Tianna.

“Largely thanks to Quinn, and that bird of hers,” said Garen. “How goes her recovery?”

“The ranger-knight has already left the city, despite the protestations of her healers,” said Tianna. “She’s as hard as brightsteel, that one. I like her.”

Garen nodded, pleased to hear Quinn was well, though a little disappointed not to have seen her before she left.

“Has there been word from the Nockmirch?” Garen asked. Tianna nodded.

“Kriel reports that Lady Odelyn is proving a capable ruler. She’s demolished the bridge you discovered, and with our aid, is fortifying her eastern borders. The training of the Nockmirch ranks goes well. They will have a substantial and well-drilled army by spring. What’s more, it would seem that her mother’s death was no natural occurrence, but a Noxian assassination. It was the first step in their bid to take control of the Nockmirch.”

Garen shook his head. The enemy was cunning.

“Lady Odelyn is strong,” he said. “She’ll be a good leader.”

“She’ll need to be,” said Tianna. “It was a good decision to leave Kriel there, to watch over things until an ambassador is in place. Perhaps a more

permanent diplomatic posting would suit him, in the future."

"He has the right temperament," agreed Garen. "Though First Shield misses his presence."

"It surprised me, how you handled matters after the battle," said Tianna, leaning forward on her elbows and steepling her fingers before her. "I would have assumed you would imprison the treacherous Lord of the Nockmirch, along with his daughter, allowing us to install a trustworthy regent. That's what *I* would have done."

Tianna stared at him without blinking.

"However," she continued, her expression softening ever so slightly. "By allowing Lady Odelyn to succeed her father, it would appear that you have gained us a stronger ally. Well done."

"Thank you, High Marshal," said Garen, allowing himself to breathe again. "I had good people around me, without whom I would not have reached this course of action."

"Well, keep them close," said Tianna. "We are surrounded by enemies. True allies are a valuable commodity indeed."

Garen nodded, then looked down, not sure how if he should give voice to a concern that had lingered with him since leaving the Nockmirch.

"Something is on your mind," said Tianna. It was a statement, not a question.

Garen said nothing. Tiana raised her eyebrows. "Well?" she said. "My time is precious, I advise you not to waste it."

"It is the duty of a lord to protect their people," said Garen, finally.

"Of course."

"And yet, it is now certain the Nockmirch will be attacked from the east in the years to come," said Garen. "Even with new defenses, new training, a

competent leader, and our military aid, its people *will* suffer. And when they do, will they thank Lady Odelyn for overturning her father's arrangement with Noxus? Will they when their children are dying?"

"Eldwyn reneged on his oaths, and opened his gates to the enemy," said Tianna. "It was dishonorable, and brought shame upon his house and his land."

"Is a leader's honor more important than the lives they are sworn to protect?" asked Garen.

"Better to die free than live as a slave," said Tianna. "Do you truly think the people of Nockmirch would be better off if they sided with our enemies?"

"Honestly, I don't know," said Garen, with a sigh. "And that bothers me."

Tianna steepled her hands before her once more, staring intently at Garen. He cursed himself for having said anything.

"There is one matter of your experience that concerns me," Tianna said.

"Oh?"

"The mage," said Tianna.

"I deeply regret letting that one escape," Garen said. "That is my failure. Great-Uncle Hargold's death cannot go unaddressed."

Tianna made a face, and waved her hand dismissively. "Stop shouldering the blame for everything untoward in the world!" she snapped. "The weight will crush you."

Garen's cheeks burned at the admonishment.

"The council is unnerved," continued Tianna. "What if someone like that attained a position of power within Demacia? What if they already *have*?"

Garen blinked. He hadn't considered such a possibility.

"It would be a disaster," he said.

“The Mageseeker Order has been petitioning for special dispensation and additional judiciary powers for months,” said Tianna. “Fear that the upper echelons of Demacian leadership could have been infiltrated gives their arguments more weight.”

“Fear should never dictate Demacian policy,” said Garen.

“I agree. Yet the mageseekers already have Jarvan’s ear,” said Tianna, turning to look out the window, across the rooftops of the great city.

“The Crown Prince still grieves the death of his father,” Garen said. “As do I. As does all of Demacia.”

“Of course,” Tianna added, “but the Crown Prince’s anger blinds him. And there are those who seek to take advantage of that.”

Garen frowned.

“I do not see Jarvan’s anger fading any time soon,” he growled. “Not while the murderer Sylas is still out there.”

Tianna turned to face Garen, and produced a tightly rolled piece of parchment, its seal broken, and held it out to him.

“I received this dispatch before dawn,” Tianna said.

“The rangers have picked up a trail?” Garen guessed, taking the parchment.

“Yes,” said Tianna.

Garen unrolled the dispatch, and read it swiftly. Once he was done, he re-rolled it and handed it back.

“I will leave immediately,” he declared.

“Spies will be watching,” said Tianna. “I would advise you to be well beyond the city by sunrise. You’ll need to move swiftly. A small strike-force will attract less attention.”

“I will take First Shield,” said Garen.

“Do what needs to be done,” said Tianna. “Strength through discipline.”

“Honor through diligence,” said Garen.

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Hailing from Sydney, Australia, Anthony developed a passion for gaming and the fantasy genre from a young age, which led him to pursue a career as a writer. He's had numerous stories, games, novels, and audio dramas published over a span of twenty years, and started playing League of Legends around Season One (playing Shaco, badly). He joined Riot Games in 2014, and now lives in Seattle, Washington, with his wife, Beth, his daughter, Maya, and a pair of slightly deranged cats, the brothers Thor and Loki.

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